Principles of online decision-making
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Contents

0.1 Introduction to Online Decision-Making 4
0.1.1 What is online (sequential) decision-making? 4
0.1.2 Three classes of models 4
0.1.3 Probability tools we will need 5
0.1.4 Reinforcement learning vs. supervised learning 6
0.1.5 Key concept: the explore-exploit tradeoff 7
0.1.6 Prerequisites 7
0.2 Optimal Stopping: the Secretary Problem 7
0.2.1 Problem statement 7
0.2.2 Optimal policy: threshold structure 8
0.2.3 General optimal threshold k 9
0.2.4 Random order vs. i.i.d. random variables 10
0.2.5 Does the goal matter? Success probability vs. expected value 10
0.2.6 Explore-exploit tradeoff, revisited 11
0.3 Multi-Armed Bandits 12
0.3.1 A bit of history and motivation 12
0.3.2 Stochastic bandits: definitions, assumptions, vocabulary 13
0.3.3 Unstructured vs. structured bandits 14
0.3.4 Review of some probability notions 15
0.3.5 Back to bandits: regret 17
0.3.6 Objective of the learner: sublinear regret 17
0.3.7 Decomposing the regret 18
0.3.8 Summary 19
0.4 Concentration of Measure 19
0.4.1 Motivation: sums of i.i.d. random variables 19
0.4.2 Large n limits 19
0.4.3 Markov and Chebyshev inequalities 20
0.4.4 Gaussian tail from the CLT 21
0.4.5 Subgaussian random variables 21
0.4.6 Tail of a subgaussian random variable 23
0.4.7 Large deviation bound for finite n 23
0.4.8 Examples of subgaussian random variables 24
0.5 The Explore-then-Commit Algorithm 24
0.5.1 Idea and definitions 24
0.5.2 Simulations: Bernoulli bandit with $k = 2$ 25
0.5.3 Regret bound for ETC with 1-subgaussian rewards 27
0.5.4 Analysis for $k = 2$ 28

0.5.5 Comparison of the bound with simulations . . . 29
0.6 Summary . . . 29
0.7 Recap . . . 30
0.7.1 Multi-armed bandits . . . 30
0.7.2 Regret . . . 30
0.7.3 Explore-then-Commit . . . 30
0.8 Adaptive Explore-then-Commit . . . 31
0.8.1 Idea: the exploration length as a stopping time . . . 31
0.8.2 Confidence intervals . . . 31
0.8.3 Using confidence intervals to decide when to commit . . . 32
0.8.4 Algorithm . . . 32
0.8.5 Simulations . . . 33
0.9 More than two arms: Sequential Elimination . . . 34
0.9.1 ETC for $k > 2$ arms . . . 34
0.9.2 From ETC to sequential elimination . . . 35
0.9.3 Simulations: adaptive ETC versus sequential elimination . . . 35
0.10 The Upper Confidence Bound (UCB) algorithm . . . 36
0.10.1 Algorithm . . . 36
0.10.2 Exploration-exploitation tradeoff in UCB . . . 36
0.10.3 Optimism in the face of uncertainty: UCB versus ETC . . . 37
0.10.4 Simulations . . . 37
0.11 Regret bound for UCB . . . 38
0.11.1 Proof outline . . . 38
0.11.2 Notation: $\hat{\mu}_i(t)$ versus $\hat{\mu}_{is}$ . . . 39
0.11.3 Step 1: the good event . . . 39
0.11.4 Step 2: on G_i, $T_i(n) \leq u_i$ . . . 40
0.11.5 Step 3: G_i is likely if u_i is large enough . . . 40
0.11.6 Step 4: choice of u_i and conclusion . . . 41
0.11.7 Simulations and comparison with ETC . . . 42
0.12 Summary . . . 43
0.13 Recap . . . 43
0.13.1 The UCB algorithm . . . 43
0.13.2 Regret and the UCB regret bound . . . 44
0.13.3 Proof strategy (recap) . . . 44
0.14 UCB in practice: confidence intervals and the role of δ . . . 44
0.14.1 Evolution of the confidence intervals . . . 44
0.14.2 The effect of δ . . . 45
0.15 A problem-independent regret bound for UCB . . . 45
0.15.1 Motivation . . . 45
0.15.2 Proof . . . 46
0.15.3 Revisiting the regret plot . . . 47
0.16 Asymptotic UCB: unknown horizon . . . 47
0.16.1 Motivation: why a fixed δ is not enough . . . 47
0.16.2 Algorithm . . . 48

0.16.3 Regret bound: proof sketch . . . 48
0.16.4 Asymptotically optimal UCB . . . 51
0.16.5 UCB: a long history . . . 51
0.17 Thompson Sampling . . . 51
0.17.1 Prelude: Bayesian statistics . . . 51
0.17.2 Bayesian view of bandits . . . 52
0.17.3 Algorithm . . . 52
0.17.4 Intuition . . . 53
0.17.5 Calculating posteriors: Beta-Bernoulli . . . 54
0.17.6 Some practical points . . . 55
0.18 Best-arm identification . . . 55
0.18.1 Motivation . . . 55
0.18.2 Formulations . . . 55
0.18.3 Intuition: why is this different from regret minimization? . . . 56
0.18.4 Sequential halving . . . 56
0.18.5 Performance of sequential halving . . . 57
0.19 Summary . . . 57

0.1 Introduction to Online Decision-Making

0.1.1 What is online (sequential) decision-making?

Online, or sequential, decision-making refers to settings in which an *agent* repeatedly decides on an action, receives feedback from the environment, and then decides on another action, and so on. Usually, the sequence of decisions coincides with time.

Three ingredients characterize this class of problems:

- **Sequential**: the agent takes a decision, observes feedback, takes another decision, etc.
- **Decision**: a decision is *irrevocable* – once taken, it cannot be undone.
- **Uncertainty**: the environment is not known in advance, so the agent must *probe* it; the future is not known either, so the agent must rely on statistical assumptions.

[Teaching a new class] Consider a class being taught for the first time. The instructor has some prior information (student background, curriculum, goals) and a finite horizon (e.g., 14 weeks of lectures). Uncertainties include the students' background, how content is best acquired, and extraneous effects (other courses, external events). Every lecture reveals new information (questions asked, homework performance, midterm results), based on which the instructor takes actions: tweaking the lectures, and students may drop or join the class.

0.1.2 Three classes of models

This course studies three families of sequential decision problems, in increasing order of complexity.

- **Optimal stopping** (the secretary problem, covered this week): the horizon is finite and the agent must commit to a choice.
- **Bandits** (about 6 weeks): the agent repeatedly decides which *arm* (option) to play; outcomes are random, and there is an optimal arm that is not known a priori. The agent must learn the value of the different options over time.
- **Reinforcement learning** (about 6 weeks): the agent learns to interact with an environment that has a *state* (i.e., memory); outcomes of actions are random and rewards can be delayed.

Example: optimal stopping – finding a parking spot

Consider the problem of finding a parking spot close to a destination, with limited lookahead: if the destination is reached without having found a spot, this is a failure. If a spot is found, the reward equals minus the distance walked to the destination. There is a clear tradeoff: parking too early means a lot of walking, while parking too late risks missing the destination entirely (or arriving too late). How should one park optimally?

Example: multi-armed bandits

In a multi-armed bandit problem, the set of actions is called the set of *arms*. The agent takes a sequence of decisions on which action (arm) to pull, and receives a reward after each action according to some reward function. In a *stochastic* bandit, the reward is random, and is independent of everything except the choice of action taken. The name traces back to Thompson [1933].

[Clinical trial] Consider running a clinical trial without unnecessarily harming patients. The gold standard for clinical trials is to randomize: randomly give each patient the drug or a placebo. There is always a nonzero probability that the medicine does not work, or is even more harmful than the placebo – so when should we decide that this is unlikely enough that we should stop giving placebos?

The classical statistical approach fixes a confidence criterion (a p-value) beforehand, which determines the size n of the trial (how many patients are needed): more patients give higher confidence. But if the medicine works very well (or seems worse than the placebo), many people stay sick needlessly while the trial runs to completion. Ideally, we should be able to abort the trial early once the outcome becomes clear – but what if this apparent trend was only a fluke?

The question is therefore: instead of assigning treatments purely at random, how do we decide, for each new patient arriving sequentially, whether to give the drug or the placebo, using all information available so far?

Remark 1 (The importance of the horizon)**.** Suppose every arm a generates a reward distributed like X_a, independent of everything else. How would you play if $n = 1$? How would you play if $n \to \infty$? This is analogous to portfolio choice: stocks have higher expected return but also higher volatility, while bonds have lower return and lower volatility – investment advice differs for a 20-year-old versus a 50-year-old. The horizon over which the agent needs to perform well is a key parameter of the problem.

Example: reinforcement learning – Atari Pong

Consider learning to play a computer game (e.g., Atari Pong). We do not (or cannot) program the rules of the game and then compute the optimal move analytically. Instead, an algorithm should observe and master the game as quickly as possible by playing and observing. Feedback comes as reward signals (+1 if the agent scores, −1 if the adversary scores). The environment has a *state* (e.g., ball position and velocity, own position), and the right action depends on this state. A key additional difficulty is that signals arrive *with delay*.

0.1.3 Probability tools we will need

Concentration results

Concentration results describe the limiting behavior of probability distributions at different "zoom levels". Suppose $X_1, \ldots, X_n$ is a sequence of i.i.d. random variables, and let $S_n = \sum_{i=1}^{n} X_i$.

- **Law of Large Numbers**: $\dfrac{S_n}{n} \to \mu$ (the average converges to the mean). This is an *asymptotic* statement ($n \to \infty$) and gives no information for a specific finite n.
- **Central Limit Theorem**: $\dfrac{S_n - n\mu}{\sqrt{n}} \to \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma^2)$, characterizing the "typical" (standard) deviation from the mean.
- **Chernoff bound**: $\mathbb{P}\left(\dfrac{S_n}{n} \geq \mu + \epsilon\right) \leq \exp(-f(\epsilon)n)$, giving a more precise tail behavior for a specific finite n, i.e., the probability of very large departures from the mean.

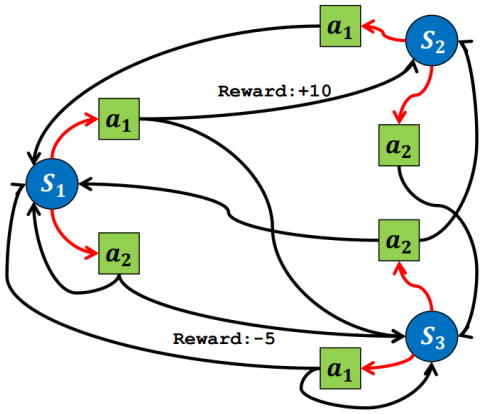
Markov chains

We are familiar with sequences of i.i.d. random variables $X_1, \ldots, X_n$ (LLN, CLT, etc.). To add "a bit of dependence", consider (X_1, X_2, X_3) with $X_1 \perp X_3 \mid X_2$: this defines a *Markov chain*. Now let the number of variables go to infinity, assume homogeneity (the probabilistic relationship between neighboring variables is the same everywhere) and discrete random variables. The chain is then described by a transition matrix P, with $P_{ij} = \mathbb{P}(X_n = j \mid X_{n-1} = i)$.

Depending on P, sets of states can have different long-term behaviors (absorbing, transient, periodic). Under certain conditions on P, the long-term behavior of the chain converges (*ergodicity*); in this ergodic regime, one is interested in the *stationary distribution* π, the normalized solution of the eigenvector problem $\pi = \pi P$.

Markov Decision Processes (MDPs)

An MDP formalizes decision-making in an environment with state. A *policy* π maps a state to an action. The goal is to maximize the reward over a long time horizon.



[Learning to walk] Model: physics of limbs, gravitation, friction with the ground. Actions: move joints. Rewards: getting to some place. Key challenges: large, continuous state and action spaces. This topic will not be covered in detail in this course.

0.1.4 Reinforcement learning vs. supervised learning

In classical supervised learning: labeled data is collected, a model is trained to give good predictions, and at test time the model is deployed and used.

In the real world, data keeps accruing during test/deployment time, which can be used to refine the model; moreover, the system might not be stationary, requiring adaptation (e.g., periodic retraining). Updating the model may also influence the future data distribution: e.g., in a recommender system, people consume the items the system recommends, so future data becomes biased toward recommended items – a potential positive feedback loop.

Reinforcement learning integrates "training" (*explore*) with "testing", i.e., using the model to accomplish something (*exploit*).

0.1.5 Key concept: the explore-exploit tradeoff

Definition 1 (Explore-exploit tradeoff)**. Explore**: collect samples to learn about the environment/model – somewhat like the training set in supervised learning; the agent does not attempt to take good decisions, but to understand the problem.
Exploit: try to take good actions/decisions – somewhat like the test set in supervised learning; the agent does try to take good decisions, even though the model is still noisy.

This tradeoff recurs across all the examples seen so far:

- **Parking**: explore (look for a better spot) vs. exploit (park now).
- **Clinical trial**: explore (give a random treatment) vs. exploit (give the treatment believed best).
- **Pong**: explore (random move) vs. exploit (best-guess move).

This course develops probabilistic models for such situations, algorithms to handle them, and analysis of the optimality of these algorithms.

0.1.6 Prerequisites

This is essentially a probability class; introductory probability is enough, although mathematical maturity helps. It is not a bad idea to take *Modèles stochastiques* in parallel, since there is some overlap (mostly Markov chains) – however, this course (PODM) is self-contained. Solid prerequisites in basic probability are required.

0.2 Optimal Stopping: the Secretary Problem

0.2.1 Problem statement

Definition 2 (Secretary problem, a.k.a. "apartment hunting problem")**.** You are looking for an apartment to rent on a hot market: you must take it or leave it forever, on the spot. You know the number of options in advance: n apartments will be viewed, and you need shelter after the last one. Every apartment has a quality level x_i, drawn i.i.d. from some *unknown* law – equivalently, one may simply assume that the apartments are viewed in a uniformly random order, with no information about the underlying probability law. The only information available at step i is the values $x_1, \dots, x_i$ seen so far (or, more precisely, their relative ranking).
Decisions are irrevocable: sign the lease immediately, or that apartment is gone forever. The goal is to maximize the probability of selecting the overall best apartment among the n.

This model captures many practical situations with the same flavor, e.g.:

- Resource allocation: how much effort to spend searching and evaluating before hiring a candidate or selecting a vendor.
- Online auctions: updating one's own bid upon observing other bids.
- Acquiring friendships/social contacts over a lifetime.

The problem is also known under other names: the *marriage problem*, the *sultan's dowry*, or the *googol game*.

0.2.2 Optimal policy: threshold structure

Theorem 1 (Form of the optimal policy)**.** *The optimal policy is necessarily of the following form, for some constant threshold k:*

(1) If x_i is not *a new maximum (relative to $x_1, \ldots, x_{i-1}$), continue.*
(2) If x_i is *a new maximum, stop (commit) if $i \geq k$; otherwise continue.*

Justification. **Why (1)?** Stopping on a value that is not a new maximum is guaranteed to fail (the true best has already appeared, or will appear later and we have already committed to a non-optimal value) – this is never a good idea.

Why (2)? We claim the optimal policy continues before k and stops at or after k upon seeing a new maximum, i.e., the policy is *monotonic*: if we decide to stop upon seeing a new maximum-so-far at position i, we must also decide to stop upon seeing a new maximum-so-far at any $j > i$.

To see this, condition on observing the maximum over $x_1, \ldots, x_i$ seen so far (i.e., $x_i > \max(x_1, \ldots, x_{i-1})$). The probability of success if we commit to x_i is exactly i/n: the overall maximum is uniformly distributed over $\{1, \ldots, n\}$, so this conditional probability of success is *increasing* in i. On the other hand, the (unconditional) probability of seeing a new maximum-so-far at step i is *decreasing* in i. Hence, if the tradeoff (value of stopping vs. probability of the opportunity arising) is favorable at i, it is even more favorable at any $j > i$. □

Small cases: $n = 1, 2, 3$

- $n = 1$: nothing to do, commit to the only option.
- $n = 2$: the best is first with probability $1/2$ and second with probability $1/2$. Either commit to the first, or (implicitly) commit to the second (=last) if not; $\mathbb{P}(\text{success}) = 1/2$.
- $n = 3$: the smallest n for which we actually "make a decision". With $k = 2$, we use the comparison between the first and second position to decide whether to take the second or the third apartment.

The table below enumerates all $3! = 6$ orderings of the ranks $\{1, 2, 3\}$ (1 = best) and the resulting success probability for each candidate threshold $k \in \{1, 2, 3\}$.

	$k = 1$	$k = 2$	$k = 3$
	1 2 3	1 2 3	1 2 3
	1 3 2	1 3 2	1 3 2
	2 1 3	2 1 3	2 1 3
	2 3 1	2 3 1	2 3 1
	3 1 2	3 1 2	3 1 2
	3 2 1	3 2 1	3 2 1
$\mathbb{P}(\text{success})$	$1/3$	$1/2$	$1/3$

The threshold $k = 2$ is optimal for $n = 3$, giving $\mathbb{P}(\text{success}) = 1/2$.

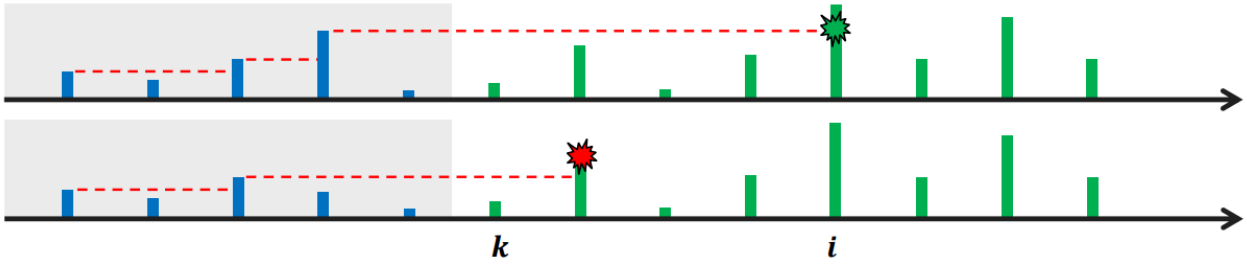
0.2.3 General optimal threshold k

Let U denote the index (position) of the true overall maximum; note that $U \sim \text{Unif}\{1, \ldots, n\}$. Let Z denote the output of the policy (its guess for U), and let E be the event "success", i.e., the policy chooses index i and i is indeed the best. Then:

$$\mathbb{P}(E) = \sum_{i=k}^{n} \mathbb{P}(Z = i \cap U = i) = \sum_{i=k}^{n} \mathbb{P}(Z = i \mid U = i)\, \mathbb{P}(U = i), \qquad \mathbb{P}(U = i) = \frac{1}{n}.$$

Computing $\mathbb{P}(Z = i \mid U = i)$. The event $\{Z = i \mid U = i\}$ holds when i is the overall best (so rule (2) is triggered with certainty at step i: success), *provided* the policy has not stopped earlier. This requires that all previous best-so-far values occur *before* k. Conditional on $\{U = i\}$, where is the best value among $x_1, \ldots, x_{i-1}$ (not necessarily the second-best overall, which could occur after i – just the best *so far*)? All we know is that it is not at i, so its position is uniformly distributed over $\{1, \ldots, i-1\}$. Hence:

$$\mathbb{P}(Z = i \mid U = i) = \mathbb{P}\big(\text{Unif}(i-1) \in \{k-1\}\big) \cdot (k-1) = \frac{k-1}{i-1}.$$



Finite n

Combining the two pieces:

$$\mathbb{P}(E) = \sum_{i=k}^{n} \frac{k-1}{i-1} \cdot \frac{1}{n} = \frac{k-1}{n} \sum_{i=k}^{n} \frac{1}{i-1} = \frac{k-1}{n}\big(H_{n-1} - H_{k-2}\big),$$

where $H_m = \sum_{j=1}^{m} \frac{1}{j}$ is the m-th harmonic number. Optimizing over k for each n gives:

n	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	20	30	40	50	100
k	1	1	2	2	3	3	3	4	4	4	7	11	15	18	37
$\mathbb{P}(E)$	1	0.5	0.5	0.458	0.433	0.428	0.414	0.410	0.406	0.399	0.384	0.379	0.376	0.374	0.371

Remarkably, $\mathbb{P}(E)$ appears to converge to a positive constant as $n \to \infty$. Also note that neither k nor $\mathbb{P}(E)$ depends on the distribution of the x_i – only on n.

Large n: the $1/e$ rule

Set $x = k/n$. As $n \to \infty$, the sum becomes an integral:

$$\mathbb{P}(E) \xrightarrow{n\to\infty} x \int_{y=x}^{1} \frac{1}{y}\, dy = -x \ln x.$$

Optimizing over x: setting $\dfrac{d\,\mathbb{P}(E)}{dx} = 0$ gives $x = e^{-1} \approx 37\%$.

Theorem 2 (The $1/e$ rule)**.** *As $n \to \infty$, the optimal threshold is $k \approx n/e$, and the optimal success probability converges to $1/e \approx 0.368$. Informally: "look at the first 37% of the candidates without committing, then leap at the next candidate that beats everything seen so far."*

0.2.4 Random order vs. i.i.d. random variables

An important assumption underlying the whole analysis is that we have *no information about future values*. Two ways to phrase this assumption, and why both matter:

- **I.i.d. random variables**: the player does not know the underlying distribution. *Counterexample if this fails*: if we knew the distribution of the x_i, we could directly compute the probability that x_i is the overall maximum; if this probability is already large, there would be no need to wait until k.
- **Rank order**: only the partial order (ranking) of the items seen so far (up to i) is available. *Counterexample if this fails*: if x_i revealed its total rank among all n items, we could simply wait for an item ranked #1 at any time and stop immediately.

The need to "pay" with some samples in order to discover the distribution and correctly judge future samples is what makes the problem interesting, and is baked into these assumptions.

0.2.5 Does the goal matter? Success probability vs. expected value

The optimal policy derived above is specific to the particular criterion adopted, namely maximizing $\mathbb{P}(Z = U)$: it never accepts anything below the maximum-so-far.

Suppose instead we wanted to maximize the *expected value* of the chosen apartment, $\mathbb{E}[x_Z]$ (i.e., rent a *good* apartment, without it being catastrophic if it is not the very best). Does the optimal policy change?

Remark 2. Yes, it does. *Counterexample*: suppose we are close to n and we observe the second-best value seen so far – it is very unlikely that this can still be beaten, so we should take it. In fact, under this new goal, we should accept anything above the *median* of the values seen so far near the end of the sequence. This policy guarantees eventual failure under the previous (probability-of-best) criterion, but performs much better in terms of expected score.

This illustrates a general lesson: the goal (objective function) fundamentally shapes what the optimal policy looks like.

0.2.6 Explore-exploit tradeoff, revisited

The explore-exploit tradeoff introduced earlier is the key underlying concept of this course:

- **Explore**: make potentially bad decisions (with respect to some specified goal) in order to estimate parameters of the system, helping make better decisions in the future.
- **Exploit**: based on these estimates, make good decisions with respect to the specified goal.

In the secretary problem, explore and exploit are *sharply separated*: there are two phases, with an a-priori threshold (k) at which the policy switches from one to the other. In bandit problems and in reinforcement learning, exploration and exploitation will instead meld together more gradually:

- **Bandits**: gradually improve estimates of the rewards of different arms, stop playing some arms earlier than others, and gradually optimize the rewards obtained.
- **Reinforcement learning**: gradually exclude states and actions that are unlikely or costly to lead to rewards, driving the system towards good states.

0.3 Multi-Armed Bandits

0.3.1 A bit of history and motivation

The name "bandit" comes from the slot machine: pulling an arm yields a reward (minus the investment), and $\mathbb{E}[\text{payoff}] < 0$ – hence a "bandit". In the old days, a slot machine used a mechanical random number generator; different machines ("one-armed bandits") can behave subtly differently. The fundamental question is: *which arm to pull*? In particular, if we play for a long time but know nothing at the beginning, how do we use the information gathered along the way optimally?

The field was initiated by William R. Thompson [*Biometrika*, 1933], motivated by clinical trials: sequential decision-making under uncertainty, aiming to minimize unnecessary harm to patients. Bandit models have many applications in online services, where there is a lot of data, a lot of decisions to make, and human intervention is generally not feasible.

Remark 3. The objective of this course is to extract *principles*: clean "vignettes" of often messier real-world situations, chosen for their mathematical tractability. The algorithms studied are not necessarily directly applicable to all real-world situations, but the underlying principles are tools that guide the design of real-world solutions.

Real-world examples

- **A/B-testing web interfaces**: automate design choices for web/online interfaces; reward = user traffic, activity, engagement time, etc.
- **Ad placement**: place ads at the right location and show the right ad at the appropriate time; reward = ad revenue.
- **News recommendations**: serve news stories of interest to every user; reward = clicks, engagement time, etc.
- **Dynamic pricing**: optimize price over time so as to sell the full inventory while maximizing revenue; reward = total revenue.
- **Monte Carlo Tree Search (MCTS)**: used in recent successes of ML approaches to game playing (Atari games, chess, Go, …). A tree captures positions already explored; the algorithm generates a path down the known tree, expands a leaf, plays randomly to the end, and propagates the reward back up. Conceptually, every node contains a bandit algorithm that learns rewards "further down" based on the choice of child node. Over time, higher-reward paths get chosen more often, while uncertainty is still handled explicitly.

Back to the clinical trial example: what might go wrong?

With a purely randomized test, each patient randomly receives the drug or the placebo. At the end of the trial, effectiveness is assessed, e.g., via a hypothesis test: fix a p-value (e.g., 0.05) and a criterion (e.g., probability of recovery twice as high as without treatment); this determines the necessary number of samples. The trial is carried out, then evaluated – success or failure.

The issue: nothing is done *during* the trial. What if, after only a short time, the data already show a strongly imbalanced outcome between the two arms?

This motivates a *sequential* approach, where decisions can be updated as data comes in, rather than fixed in advance.

Reminder: p-value

A hypothesis test is a probabilistic proof by contradiction. We fix a **null hypothesis** H_0 (the status quo, e.g. "the new treatment is no better than the old one") and an **alternative hypothesis** H_1 (what we want to show, e.g. "the new treatment is better").
Given a test statistic T (e.g. the number of cured patients) with observed value t_{obs}, the **p-value** is the probability, *assuming* H_0 *is true*, of observing a result at least as extreme as the one we observed:

$$p = \mathbb{P}\left(T \geq t_{\text{obs}} \mid H_0\right)$$

Decision rule. We fix a significance level α *before* looking at the data (typically $\alpha = 0.05$):

- If $p \leq \alpha$: we **reject** H_0, and the result is statistically significant.
- If $p > \alpha$: we **fail to reject** H_0. This does *not* mean that H_0 is true, only that the data does not provide enough evidence against it.

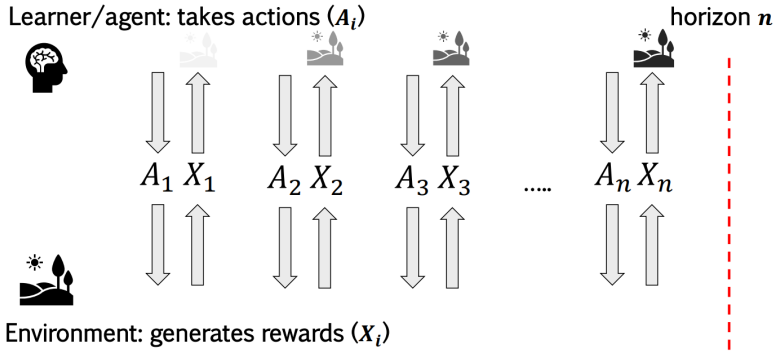
Errors.

- **Type I error** (false positive): rejecting H_0 while it is true. By construction, this happens with probability α.
- **Type II error** (false negative): not rejecting H_0 while it is false. This happens with probability β, and $1 - \beta$ is called the **power** of the test.

0.3.2 Stochastic bandits: definitions, assumptions, vocabulary

The basic interaction loop is as follows: the **learner/agent** takes actions A_i, and the **environment** generates rewards X_i, over a **horizon** n:

$$A_1, X_1, A_2, X_2, A_3, X_3, \ldots, A_n, X_n.$$



Definition 3 (History)**.** The history up to time t is $H_t = (A_1, X_1, A_2, X_2, \ldots, A_t, X_t)$. It contains all the information the learner has so far about the environment.

Definition 4 (Policy)**.** A policy π is a map from history to action: $A_t = \pi(H_{t-1})$. More specifically, the action can be random: π_t is a conditional distribution over A_t given $A_1, X_1, A_2, X_2, \ldots, A_{t-1}, X_{t-1}$ (but it cannot depend on the future).

Definition 5 (Environment)**.** The environment is a map from $A_1, X_1, A_2, X_2, \ldots, A_t$ to X_t (possibly random).

Goal. Maximize the cumulative reward up to the horizon n: $S_n = \sum_{i=1}^{n} X_i$.

Remark 4 (Key assumption)**.** The learner does *not* know the environment at the beginning, although it might know some *class* of possible environments.

Definition 6 (Regret)**.** The regret of the learner relative to a policy π^* is the expected reward under π^* minus the expected reward achieved by the learner – the "cost of ignorance". Usually, π^* is the optimal policy for the environment, i.e., a policy that knows the environment perfectly.

0.3.3 Unstructured vs. structured bandits

Definition 7 (Unstructured bandit)**.** Intuitively, an unstructured bandit is one where pulling one arm provides no information on the reward distribution of other arms. Formally, the environment class is

$$\mathcal{E} = \{\nu = (P_a : a \in \mathcal{A}) : P_a \in \mathcal{M}_a \text{ for all } a \in \mathcal{A}\},$$

where $\mathcal{M}_a$ is a family (set) of possible distributions P_a for action a. In other words, $\mathcal{E} = \bigtimes_{a\in\mathcal{A}} \mathcal{M}_a$ is a *product space*: any combination of elements from the $\mathcal{M}_a$'s is possible. This ensures that knowing anything about P_a provides no information about $P_{a'}$ for $a' \neq a$.

Remark 5. The objects in this definition live at different levels:

- P_a is **one** distribution: the true (unknown) reward distribution of arm a, e.g. Ber(0.7).
- $\mathcal{M}_a$ is a **set** of distributions: all candidates that P_a could be, i.e. what we assume about arm a before playing. For instance, $\mathcal{M}_a = \{\text{Ber}(p) : p \in [0,1]\}$ (binary rewards), $\mathcal{M}_a = \{\mathcal{N}(\mu, 1) : \mu \in \mathbb{R}\}$ (Gaussian with known variance), or all distributions supported on $[0,1]$ (bounded rewards).
- $\nu = (P_a : a \in \mathcal{A})$ is a **tuple** of distributions, one per arm: it is *one* specific environment, e.g. $\nu = (\text{Ber}(0.7), \text{Ber}(0.4))$.
- $\mathcal{E}$ is a **set** of environments: all those consistent with our assumptions.

The learner does not know ν (this is what it must learn), it only knows that $\nu \in \mathcal{E}$. Learning amounts to progressively narrowing down the candidates in each $\mathcal{M}_a$ until P_a is identified well enough. The guarantees of an algorithm hold only if the true P_a indeed belongs to the assumed $\mathcal{M}_a$.

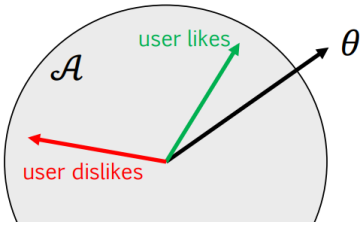
Examples of unstructured bandit classes

Name	Parametric	Definition
Bernoulli	Yes	$\mathcal{B}(\mu_i)$, $\mu_i \in [0,1]$
Uniform	Yes	$\mathcal{U}(a_i, b_i)$, $a_i \leq b_i \in \mathbb{R}$
Gaussian, known variance	Yes	$\mathcal{N}(\mu_i, \sigma^2)$
Gaussian, unknown variance	Yes	$\mathcal{N}(\mu_i, \sigma_i^2)$
Finite variance	No	$\mathbb{V}(P_i) \leq \sigma^2$
Bounded support	No	$\text{Supp}(P_i) \subseteq [a, b]$
Subgaussian	No	P_i is σ-subgaussian

Definition 8 (Structured bandit)**.** Intuitively, a structured bandit has an environment class where the reward of one arm provides information on the reward distribution of other arms.

Examples.

- *"Complementary Bernoulli" bandit*: $\mathcal{A} = \{1, 2\}$, $\mathcal{E} = \{(\mathcal{B}(\theta), \mathcal{B}(1-\theta)) : \theta \in [0,1]\}$. One could learn everything by playing only one arm forever. Example: two mutually exclusive options to click on a webpage.
- *Stochastic linear bandit*: $\mathcal{A} \subset \mathbb{R}^d$ (an uncountably infinite action space), $\theta \in \mathbb{R}^d$, $\mathcal{E} = \{\nu_\theta : \theta \in \mathbb{R}^d\}$ with $\nu_\theta = \{\mathcal{N}(\langle a, \theta\rangle, 1) : a \in \mathcal{A}\}$. Example: a recommender system, where θ captures unknown user preferences and a captures the feature vector of an item; $\langle a, \theta\rangle = a^T\theta$ is the inner product measuring how much the user likes item a.



Thought experiment: the case of no noise

In this idealized setting, we assume that pulling an arm reveals its *exact* expected reward, rather than a noisy sample drawn around it: $r_t = \mu_a$ instead of $r_t = \mu_a + \varepsilon_t$. In other words, a single pull gives perfect information about the arm's true mean, with no randomness to average out. This is of course unrealistic (real feedback is always noisy), but it is a useful thought experiment to understand how much easier the bandit problem becomes once uncertainty is removed.

- **Unstructured bandit**: try each of the k arms once, observe a (deterministic) reward, then play the best arm forever – no more regret is incurred afterwards; the cumulative regret is constant.
- **Structured bandit**: e.g., in the complementary Bernoulli case, there is one permanent winner and one permanent loser, so pulling once suffices to be perfect forever. In the stochastic linear case, getting exact inner products (i.e., projections) requires that the set of actions spans $\mathbb{R}^d$; then d pulls suffice to estimate θ perfectly.

This noiseless setting is not very interesting, nor realistic in most practical settings. **The main topic in bandit theory is dealing with noise in the reward**, which gives rise to a non-zero expected regret "forever".

0.3.4 Review of some probability notions

CDF, CCDF, density

For a continuous random variable A:

$$F_A(a) = \mathbb{P}(A \leq a), \qquad F'_A(a) = \mathbb{P}(A > a) = 1 - F_A(a) \text{ (CCDF)}, \qquad f_A(a) = \frac{dF_A(a)}{da} \geq 0.$$

Independence

Two random variables are independent iff $F_{A,B}(a,b) = F_A(a)F_B(b)$ for all a, b: information on one variable provides no information on the other.

A set of random variables is **pairwise independent** iff every pair is independent. A set of random variables is **mutually independent** iff $F_{A,B,C}(a,b,c) = F_A(a)F_B(b)F_C(c)$ (for three variables; analogously for more): any information on all the other variables provides no information on a target variable.

Remark 6. Mutual independence is *strictly stronger* than pairwise independence!

Let $A, B \sim \mathcal{B}(1/2)$ i.i.d., and let $C = A \oplus B$ (XOR). Contrast the two joint laws below (left: A, B, C constructed this way; right: $A, B, C \sim \mathcal{B}(1/2)$ i.i.d. and mutually independent):

ABC	$\mathbb{P}$
000	1/4
001	0
010	0
011	1/4
100	0
101	1/4
110	1/4
111	0

ABC	$\mathbb{P}$
000	1/8
001	1/8
010	1/8
011	1/8
100	1/8
101	1/8
110	1/8
111	1/8

In the XOR construction, every *pair* (A, B), (A, C), (B, C) is uniform on $\{0, 1\}^2$ with all four combinations having probability $1/4$ – i.e., every pair is independent. However, the three variables are *not* mutually independent: knowing any two of them determines the third exactly.

Conditional independence

Definition 9. A and B are conditionally independent given C iff, in the discrete case,

$$\mathbb{P}(A \le a, B \le b \mid C = c) = \mathbb{P}(A \le a \mid C = c)\,\mathbb{P}(B \le b \mid C = c) \quad \text{for all } a, b, c\ (\mathbb{P}(C = c) > 0),$$

or, in the continuous case, $f_{AB|C}(a, b \mid c) = f_{A|C}(a \mid c)\, f_{B|C}(b \mid c)$ for all a, b, c (with $f_C(c) > 0$).

Intuitively: if C is known, then A provides no further information about B (and vice versa). The notions of pairwise and mutual independence also extend naturally to conditional independence when there are more than two variables.

Expectation

$$\mathbb{E}[X] = \mu_X = \begin{cases} \sum_{x_i} x_i\, \mathbb{P}(X = x_i) & \text{discrete} \\ \int x f_X(x)\, dx & \text{continuous} \end{cases}$$

Some important properties:

- **Linearity**: $\mathbb{E}[A + B] = \mathbb{E}[A] + \mathbb{E}[B]$ for any A, B.
- **Product**: $\mathbb{E}[AB] = \mathbb{E}[A]\,\mathbb{E}[B]$ if $A \perp B$, but this is *not* true in general.
- For $A \ge 0$: $\mathbb{E}[A] = \int_0^\infty F'_A(x)\, dx$ (integral of the CCDF).
- $\mathbb{E}[\mathbf{1}\{E\}] = \mathbb{P}(E)$, where $\mathbf{1}(E)$ is the indicator of event E.

Conditional expectation

Definition 10. $\mathbb{E}[A \mid B = b] = \sum_a a\, \mathbb{P}(A = a \mid B = b) =: f(b)$, and $\mathbb{E}[A \mid B] = f(B)$. Note that this is a *random variable* in B.

Let $B \sim \mathcal{U}(0, 1)$ and $A \sim \mathcal{B}(B)$ (i.e., a Bernoulli whose parameter is itself the random variable B). Then $\mathbb{E}[A \mid B] = B$.

Further properties:

- If $A \perp B$, then $\mathbb{E}[A \mid B] = \mathbb{E}[A]$.
- "Pulling out what is known": $\mathbb{E}[A\, g(B) \mid B] = g(B)\, \mathbb{E}[A \mid B]$, since conditional on $B = b$, $g(B) = g(b)$ is a constant and can be pulled in front of the sum/integral.
- **Tower property (law of total expectation)**: $\mathbb{E}[\mathbb{E}[A \mid B]] = \mathbb{E}[A]$.

[Using the tower property] Let $C \sim \text{Unif}(-1, 1)$, and let $A = \mathcal{N}(C, 1)$, $B = \mathcal{N}(C, 1)$, with $A \perp B \mid C$ (i.e., $A - C - B$ forms a Markov chain). Note that A and B are *dependent* (even though conditionally

independent given C). Suppose we need to compute $\mathbb{E}[AB]$. Rather than computing the joint density $f_{AB}(a,b)$ and integrating $\iint ab\, f_{AB}(a,b)\, da\, db$, we can use the tower property:

$$\mathbb{E}[AB] = \mathbb{E}\big[\mathbb{E}[AB \mid C]\big].$$

By conditional independence, $\mathbb{E}[AB \mid C = c] = \mathbb{E}[A \mid C = c]\,\mathbb{E}[B \mid C = c] = c^2$. Hence

$$\mathbb{E}\big[\mathbb{E}[AB \mid C]\big] = \mathbb{E}[C^2] = \int_{-1}^{1} \frac{1}{2} c^2\, dc = \frac{1}{3}.$$

0.3.5 Back to bandits: regret

Definition 11 (Expected and maximum reward)**.** For a stochastic bandit given by $\nu = (P_a : a \in \mathcal{A})$, the expected reward of arm a is

$$\mu_a(\nu) = \int_{-\infty}^{+\infty} x\, dP_a(x) = \mathbb{E}[X], \quad X \sim P_a,$$

and the maximum expected reward is $\mu^*(\nu) = \max_{a \in \mathcal{A}} \mu_a(\nu)$.

Definition 12 (Regret)**.** The regret of policy π on bandit instance ν is

$$R_n(\pi, \nu) = n\mu^* - \mathbb{E}\left[\sum_{t=1}^{n} X_t\right].$$

Note that the regret is *not* a random quantity (the randomness has already been integrated out via the expectation).

Lemma 1. *(a) $R_n(\pi, \nu) \geq 0$ for all policies π.*
(b) The (oracle) policy π choosing $A_t \in \arg\max_a \mu_a$ for all t satisfies $R_n(\pi, \nu) = 0$.
(c) If $R_n(\pi, \nu) = 0$ for some policy π, then $\mathbb{P}(\mu_{A_t} = \mu^*) = 1$ for all $t \in [n]$.

0.3.6 Objective of the learner: sublinear regret

A policy incurring **linear regret** $\Theta(n)$ is trivial to achieve and provides no interesting guarantee – it does not require learning anything, so it is "too easy". A slightly more ambitious objective is **sublinear regret**: we look for policies such that, for all $\nu \in \mathcal{E}$,

$$\lim_{n \to \infty} \frac{R_n(\pi, \nu)}{n} = 0 \qquad \text{(also written } R_n = o(n)\text{)}.$$

This means that, in the long run, the learner chooses the optimal action almost always. (Usually, we are interested in even more ambitious objectives, e.g., controlling the rate at which R_n grows.)

In general, the learner needs to discover the arm (or, for structured bandits, some subset of arms) with the largest mean efficiently. For this, it needs to pull each arm (unstructured case) – or some number of arms (structured case) – a number of times to estimate the environment's parameters. This is exactly the **explore-exploit tradeoff**: exploring (playing all arms to improve the estimators) versus exploiting (playing the best arm(s) to improve the regret).

0.3.7 Decomposing the regret

Definition 13 (Suboptimality gap)**.** The suboptimality gap of action a is $\Delta_a(\nu) = \mu^*(\nu) - \mu_a(\nu)$.

Definition 14 (Action count)**.** The action count of action a by time t is $T_a(t) = \sum_{s=1}^{t} \mathbf{1}\{A_s = a\}$. Note that $T_a(t)$ is a *random variable*, since it depends on the random rewards observed before t (through the policy's choices).

Lemma 2 (Regret decomposition)**.** *For any policy π and environment ν, the regret satisfies*

$$R_n(\pi, \nu) = \sum_{a \in \mathcal{A}} \Delta_a \, \mathbb{E}[T_a(n)].$$

Proof. We rewrite the n-step regret, splitting the sum over time into a sum over arms and using the indicator of which arm is played at each step:

$$R_n = n\mu^* - \mathbb{E}\left[\sum_{t=1}^{n} X_t\right] = \sum_{a \in \mathcal{A}} \sum_{t=1}^{n} \mathbb{E}\big[(\mu^* - X_t)\, \mathbf{1}(A_t = a)\big].$$

By the tower property (conditioning on A_t):

$$= \sum_{a \in \mathcal{A}} \sum_{t=1}^{n} \mathbb{E}\Big[\mathbb{E}\big[(\mu^* - X_t)\, \mathbf{1}(A_t = a) \mid A_t\big]\Big].$$

Now, conditional on A_t, the indicator $\mathbf{1}(A_t = a)$ is a constant and can be pulled out:

$$\mathbb{E}\big[(\mu^* - X_t)\, \mathbf{1}(A_t = a) \mid A_t\big] = \mathbf{1}(A_t = a)\, \mathbb{E}[\mu^* - X_t \mid A_t] = \mathbf{1}(A_t = a)\, (\mu^* - \mu_{A_t}),$$

using the (by-assumption) fact that $\mathbb{E}[X_t \mid A_t] = \mu_{A_t}$. Since the first factor is nonzero only when $A_t = a$, we may replace μ_{A_t} by μ_a:

$$\mathbf{1}(A_t = a)\, (\mu^* - \mu_{A_t}) = \mathbf{1}(A_t = a)\, (\mu^* - \mu_a) = \mathbf{1}(A_t = a)\, \Delta_a.$$

Putting everything together:

$$R_n = \sum_{a \in \mathcal{A}} \sum_{t=1}^{n} \mathbb{E}\big[\mathbf{1}(A_t = a)\big]\, \Delta_a = \sum_{a \in \mathcal{A}} \Delta_a \sum_{t=1}^{n} \mathbb{P}(A_t = a) = \sum_{a \in \mathcal{A}} \Delta_a \, \mathbb{E}[T_a(n)],$$

since $\sum_{t=1}^{n} \mathbf{1}(A_t = a) = T_a(n)$. □

Remark 7 (Intuition)**.** The learner should pull arms with low (or zero) suboptimality gap, and minimize the expected number of pulls of arms with high suboptimality gap. This is not exactly shocking – the challenge of the course is devising algorithms that achieve this efficiently, *without* knowing the gaps Δ_a in advance.

0.3.8 Summary

- The stochastic bandit: a player and an environment interact via actions A_t and (instantaneous) rewards X_t.
- Different assumptions about the possible environments $\mathcal{E}$ are possible (unstructured vs. structured); this assumption is important, because the player needs to figure out everything else by probing, i.e., exploring.
- Regret $R_n(\pi, \nu)$: how much is lost (over horizon n) because the environment is not known in advance.
- Regret decomposition: the regret decomposes as a sum, over all arms, of their suboptimality gap Δ_a times the expected number of times that arm was played, $\mathbb{E}[T_a(n)]$.

Lecture 3 — 2026-09-23: Concentration of Measure and Explore-then-Commit

0.4 Concentration of Measure

0.4.1 Motivation: sums of i.i.d. random variables

To analyze bandit algorithms, we have to deal with sums of random rewards (hence of random regrets). The building block is the following setting.

Let $X_1, X_2, \ldots, X_n$ be i.i.d. random variables whose mean and variance exist:

$$\mu = \mathbb{E}[X], \qquad \sigma^2 = \mathbb{V}[X] = \mathbb{E}\big[(X - \mathbb{E}[X])^2\big].$$

A natural *estimator* of μ is the empirical mean

$$\hat{\mu} = \frac{1}{n}\sum_{i=1}^{n} X_i =: \frac{S_n}{n}.$$

It satisfies:

- $\mathbb{E}[\hat{\mu}] = \mu$: $\hat{\mu}$ is an *unbiased* estimator;
- $\mathbb{V}[\hat{\mu}] = \mathbb{E}\big[(\hat{\mu} - \mu)^2\big] = \dfrac{\sigma^2}{n}$: the variance of the estimator decreases with n.

The question of this chapter is: *how close to μ is $\hat{\mu}$, with what probability, and for a given finite n?* We go through increasingly precise answers: law of large numbers, central limit theorem, Markov/Chebyshev inequalities, and finally exponential (Chernoff-type) bounds valid for finite n.

0.4.2 Large n limits

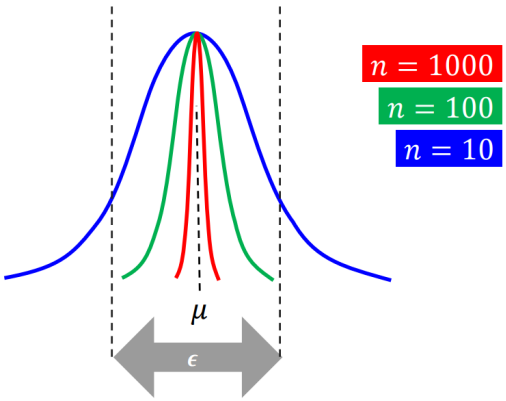
Law of large numbers (LLN)

Theorem 3 (Law of large numbers)**.** *Let $X_1, \ldots, X_n$ be i.i.d. with mean μ.*

- ***Weak law**: for every $\epsilon > 0$, $\lim_{n\to\infty} \mathbb{P}\big(|S_n - n\mu| \geq n\epsilon\big) = 0$.*
- ***Strong law**: $\mathbb{P}\left(\lim_{n\to\infty} \dfrac{S_n}{n} = \mu\right) = 1$.*

Remark 8 (Two notions of convergence)**.** The weak law is a statement of *convergence in probability*, the strong law a statement of *almost sure convergence*. The latter is strictly stronger.
Example of a (non i.i.d.) sequence that converges to 0 in probability but not almost surely: let the Y_n be independent with $Y_n = 1$ with probability $1/n$ and $Y_n = 0$ otherwise. Then

$\mathbb{P}(Y_n = 1) = 1/n \to 0$, so $Y_n \to 0$ in probability; but since $\sum_n 1/n = \infty$, almost every trajectory ω contains infinitely many 1's, so $Y_n(\omega)$ does not converge to 0.



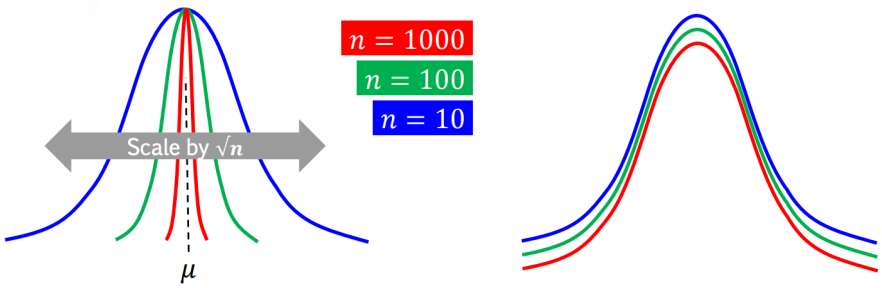
Note that the LLN is an *asymptotic* statement ($n \to \infty$): it says nothing about the probability of a deviation for a specific finite n.

Central limit theorem (CLT)

The LLN says that S_n/n concentrates around μ. The CLT tells us at which *scale*: rescale $\hat{\mu} - \mu$ by the inverse of its standard deviation $(1/\sqrt{n})$, i.e., look at $S_n - n\mu$ divided by $\sqrt{n}$:

$$\frac{S_n - n\mu}{\sqrt{n}} \xrightarrow{n\to\infty} \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma^2).$$

Equivalently, for large n, $\mathbb{P}\big(S_n - n\mu \geq n\epsilon\big) \to \mathbb{P}\big(\mathcal{N}(0,\sigma^2) \geq \epsilon\sqrt{n}\big)$.
This is the primary reason why the Gaussian law is so central (in addition to its stability under addition).



0.4.3 Markov and Chebyshev inequalities

Theorem 4 (Markov's inequality)**.** *For any random variable X and any $\epsilon > 0$,*

$$\mathbb{P}(|X| \geq \epsilon) \leq \frac{\mathbb{E}|X|}{\epsilon}.$$

Proof. Set $Y = |X| \geq 0$ with density f. Then

$$\mathbb{E}[Y] = \int_0^\infty y f(y)\, dy \geq \int_\epsilon^\infty y f(y)\, dy \geq \epsilon \int_\epsilon^\infty f(y)\, dy = \epsilon\, \mathbb{P}(Y \geq \epsilon).$$

□

Theorem 5 (Chebyshev's inequality)**.** *For any random variable X with finite variance and any $\epsilon > 0$,*

$$\mathbb{P}\big(|X - \mathbb{E}X| \geq \epsilon\big) \leq \frac{\mathbb{V}[X]}{\epsilon^2}.$$

Proof. Apply Markov's inequality to the non-negative random variable $(X - \mathbb{E}X)^2$ with threshold ϵ^2. □

Applied to the empirical mean (whose variance is σ^2/n):

$$\mathbb{P}\big(|\hat{\mu} - \mu| \geq \epsilon\big) \leq \frac{\sigma^2}{n\epsilon^2}.$$

- **Pro**: a nice, very general bound: only the mean and the variance are needed, and it holds for every finite n.
- **Con**: the bound is loose, it only decreases as $1/n$.

We need something much stronger for a meaningful analysis of bandit algorithms.

0.4.4 Gaussian tail from the CLT

By the CLT, $\dfrac{S_n - n\mu}{\sqrt{n\sigma^2}} \to \mathcal{N}(0,1)$. What if the normalized sum were *exactly* Gaussian? Let $Z \sim \mathcal{N}(0,1)$; we want to bound

$$\mathbb{P}(Z \geq z) = \int_z^\infty \frac{1}{\sqrt{2\pi}} \exp\left(-\frac{x^2}{2}\right) dx.$$

This integral has no closed form, so we look for a bound. Since $x/z \geq 1$ on the domain of integration ($x \geq z > 0$),

$$\int_z^\infty \frac{1}{\sqrt{2\pi}} e^{-x^2/2}\, dx \leq \frac{1}{\sqrt{2\pi}} \int_z^\infty \frac{x}{z}\, e^{-x^2/2}\, dx = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2\pi}\, z} \exp\left(-\frac{z^2}{2}\right).$$

Now, using $\hat{\mu} - \mu = \dfrac{S_n - n\mu}{n}$ and taking $z = \epsilon\sqrt{n/\sigma^2}$, the CLT heuristic gives

$$\mathbb{P}(\hat{\mu} - \mu \geq \epsilon) \;\longrightarrow\; \mathbb{P}\left(Z \geq \epsilon\sqrt{\tfrac{n}{\sigma^2}}\right) \leq \sqrt{\frac{\sigma^2}{2\pi n\epsilon^2}}\, \exp\left(-\frac{n\epsilon^2}{2\sigma^2}\right).$$

- **Pro**: much tighter than Chebyshev in general – *exponential* in n versus $1/n$.
- **Con**: this is an *asymptotic* result: the CLT does not allow us to bound the probability for a finite n.

We will need to pay for this limitation by making additional assumptions on the noise: **subgaussianity**.

0.4.5 Subgaussian random variables

Definition 15 (Subgaussian random variable)**.** A random variable X is *σ-subgaussian* if its moment-generating function $M_X(\lambda) = \mathbb{E}[e^{\lambda X}]$ satisfies, for all $\lambda \in \mathbb{R}$,

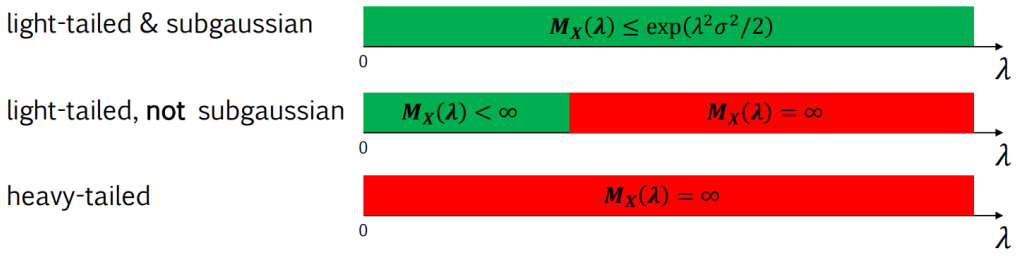
$$M_X(\lambda) = \mathbb{E}\big[e^{\lambda X}\big] \leq \exp\left(\frac{\lambda^2\sigma^2}{2}\right).$$

Equivalently, in terms of the cumulant-generating function,

$$\psi_X(\lambda) = \log M_X(\lambda) \leq \frac{1}{2}\lambda^2\sigma^2$$

for all $\lambda \in \mathbb{R}$.

Remark 9.
- If X is σ-subgaussian, then it is also σ'-subgaussian for any $\sigma' > \sigma$.
- Interpretation: the right-hand side $\exp(\lambda^2\sigma^2/2)$ is exactly the MGF of $\mathcal{N}(0, \sigma^2)$. A subgaussian variable has an MGF dominated by that of a Gaussian, i.e., its tail is at least as light as a Gaussian tail: "nice" noise with "no big excesses".
- Three cases can be distinguished: *heavy-tailed* variables ($M_X(\lambda) = \infty$ for all $\lambda \neq 0$), *light-tailed but not subgaussian* ($M_X(\lambda) < \infty$ on a neighborhood of 0 but $M_X(\lambda) = \infty$ for large $|\lambda|$, or M_X not dominated by the Gaussian one), and *light-tailed and subgaussian* ($M_X(\lambda) \leq \exp(\lambda^2\sigma^2/2)$ for all λ).



Properties of subgaussian random variables

Lemma 3. *Assume X is σ-subgaussian. Then:*
(a) $\mathbb{E}[X] = 0$ and $\mathbb{V}[X] \leq \sigma^2$;
(b) for any $\alpha \in \mathbb{R}$, αX is $|\alpha|\sigma$-subgaussian;
(c) if X_1 is σ_1-subgaussian, X_2 is σ_2-subgaussian and $X_1 \perp X_2$, then $X_1 + X_2$ is $\sqrt{\sigma_1^2 + \sigma_2^2}$-subgaussian.

Remark 10 (Abuse of notation)**.** We sometimes refer to subgaussian random variables that are *not* zero-mean; by this we mean that $X - \mathbb{E}X$ is subgaussian.

Proof of (a), sketch. Compare the Taylor expansions of both sides of $\mathbb{E}[e^{\lambda X}] \leq \exp(\lambda^2\sigma^2/2)$ around $\lambda = 0$. On the left,

$$e^{\lambda X} = 1 + \lambda X + \frac{\lambda^2 X^2}{2} + o(\lambda^2) \implies \mathbb{E}\left[e^{\lambda X}\right] = 1 + \lambda\,\mathbb{E}X + \frac{\lambda^2\,\mathbb{E}X^2}{2} + o(\lambda^2),$$

and, once we know $\mathbb{E}X = 0$ (the linear term in λ must vanish, otherwise the inequality would fail for small λ of the appropriate sign), $\mathbb{E}X^2 = \mathbb{V}X$, so the left side equals $1 + \frac{\lambda^2}{2}\mathbb{V}X + o(\lambda^2)$. On the right, $\exp(\lambda^2\sigma^2/2) = 1 + \frac{\sigma^2\lambda^2}{2} + o(\lambda^2)$. Hence

$$\mathbb{V}X + \frac{o(\lambda^2)}{\lambda^2/2} \leq \sigma^2 + \frac{o(\lambda^2)}{\lambda^2/2},$$

and taking $\lambda \to 0$ gives $\mathbb{V}X \leq \sigma^2$.
(b) follows since $\mathbb{E}[e^{\lambda\alpha X}] \leq \exp(\lambda^2\alpha^2\sigma^2/2)$; (c) follows from independence: $\mathbb{E}[e^{\lambda(X_1+X_2)}] = \mathbb{E}[e^{\lambda X_1}]\,\mathbb{E}[e^{\lambda X_2}] \leq \exp\left(\lambda^2(\sigma_1^2 + \sigma_2^2)/2\right)$. □

0.4.6 Tail of a subgaussian random variable

Theorem 6 (Tail bound)**.** *If X is σ-subgaussian, then for all $\epsilon > 0$,*

$$\mathbb{P}(X \geq \epsilon) \leq \exp\left(-\frac{\epsilon^2}{2\sigma^2}\right).$$

Proof. Let $\lambda > 0$. By monotonicity of exp, then Markov's inequality, then the definition of subgaussianity,

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbb{P}(X \geq \epsilon) &= \mathbb{P}\big(\exp(\lambda X) \geq \exp(\lambda\epsilon)\big) \\ &\leq \mathbb{E}\big[\exp(\lambda X)\big]\,\exp(-\lambda\epsilon) \\ &\leq \exp\left(\frac{\lambda^2\sigma^2}{2} - \lambda\epsilon\right).\end{aligned}$$

This holds for all $\lambda > 0$, so we may choose λ freely: taking $\lambda = \epsilon/\sigma^2$ (the minimizer of the exponent) gives $\exp\big(-\epsilon^2/(2\sigma^2)\big)$. □

The same argument gives the corresponding inequality for the left tail, so that, combining both tails (union bound),

$$\mathbb{P}(|X| \geq \epsilon) \leq 2\exp\left(-\frac{\epsilon^2}{2\sigma^2}\right).$$

Confidence intervals

Inverting this relationship gives *confidence intervals* for X. Fix a small probability (error tolerance) $\delta \in (0, 1)$. Solving $\exp(-\epsilon^2/(2\sigma^2)) = \delta$ for ϵ:

$$\mathbb{P}\left(X \geq \sqrt{2\sigma^2 \ln(1/\delta)}\right) \leq \delta.$$

For the two-sided version, we use the **union bound** $\mathbb{P}(A \cup B) \leq \mathbb{P}(A) + \mathbb{P}(B)$, which yields the factor 2:

$$\mathbb{P}\left(|X| \geq \sqrt{2\sigma^2 \ln(2/\delta)}\right) \leq \delta.$$

So, with probability at least $1 - \delta$, X concentrates in the confidence interval

$$\left[-\sqrt{2\sigma^2 \ln\tfrac{2}{\delta}},\ +\sqrt{2\sigma^2 \ln\tfrac{2}{\delta}}\right].$$

We will apply such confidence intervals to characterize the estimators of per-arm reward in different bandit algorithms.

0.4.7 Large deviation bound for finite n

Theorem 7 (Concentration of the empirical mean)**.** *Assume that $X_i - \mu$, $i = 1, \ldots, n$, are independent σ-subgaussian random variables. Then for any $\epsilon > 0$,*

$$\mathbb{P}(\hat{\mu} \geq \mu + \epsilon) \leq \exp\left(-\frac{n\epsilon^2}{2\sigma^2}\right).$$

Proof. $\hat{\mu} - \mu = \frac{1}{n}\sum_{i=1}^{n}(X_i - \mu)$ is $\sigma/\sqrt{n}$-subgaussian (by properties (b) and (c): the sum is $\sqrt{n}\sigma$-subgaussian, and scaling by $1/n$ gives $\sigma/\sqrt{n}$). Apply the tail bound of the previous theorem with parameter $\sigma/\sqrt{n}$. □

Equivalently, $\mathbb{P}(S_n - n\mu \geq n\epsilon) \leq \exp\left(-n\epsilon^2/(2\sigma^2)\right)$. This is a bound similar to what the CLT suggests, but this time it is a true bound valid for every finite n – at the price of applying only to a (much smaller) class of variables. On a semi-log plot, the bound is a straight line in n with slope $-\epsilon^2/(2\sigma^2)$.

Confidence intervals for the mean. Inverting as before:

$$\mathbb{P}\left(\mu \geq \hat{\mu} + \sqrt{\frac{2\sigma^2 \ln(1/\delta)}{n}}\right) \leq \delta, \qquad \mathbb{P}\left(\mu \leq \hat{\mu} - \sqrt{\frac{2\sigma^2 \ln(1/\delta)}{n}}\right) \leq \delta,$$

and, two-sided,

$$\mathbb{P}\left(\mu \in \left[\hat{\mu} - \sqrt{\frac{2\sigma^2 \ln(2/\delta)}{n}},\ \hat{\mu} + \sqrt{\frac{2\sigma^2 \ln(2/\delta)}{n}}\right]\right) \geq 1 - \delta.$$

The width of the interval shrinks as $1/\sqrt{n}$ and grows only as $\sqrt{\ln(1/\delta)}$ when we demand more confidence.

0.4.8 Examples of subgaussian random variables

- **Gaussian is subgaussian**: $X \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma^2)$ has $M_X(\lambda) = \exp(\lambda^2\sigma^2/2)$, hence is σ-subgaussian (with equality in the definition).
- **Bounded is subgaussian**: if $X \in [a, b]$ almost surely, then X is $\frac{b-a}{2}$-subgaussian (Hoeffding's lemma).
  In particular, if $|X| \leq a$ almost surely, then X is a-subgaussian. For instance, a Bernoulli variable is $\frac{1}{2}$-subgaussian.
- **Exponential is *not* subgaussian** (its tail is not light enough!): for $X \sim \text{Exp}(1/\mu)$ (mean μ),

$$M_X(\lambda) = \int_0^\infty \mu^{-1} e^{-x/\mu} e^{\lambda x}\, dx = \begin{cases} (1-\lambda\mu)^{-1} & \lambda < 1/\mu \\ \infty & \text{otherwise.} \end{cases}$$

  The MGF is infinite for $\lambda \geq 1/\mu$, whereas the subgaussian condition requires it to be finite (and bounded by a Gaussian MGF) for *all* λ.

0.5 The Explore-then-Commit Algorithm

0.5.1 Idea and definitions

Recall the secretary problem: pure exploration for a fixed number of steps, then pure exploitation. We can try a similar policy for bandits: invest some predetermined number of samples to estimate the mean reward of each arm, then play the empirically best arm until the horizon n.

Definition 16 (Estimated reward and number of pulls)**.** For an arm i and a time t,

$$T_i(t) = \sum_{s=1}^{t} \mathbb{I}\{A_s = i\}, \qquad \hat{\mu}_i(t) = \frac{1}{T_i(t)} \sum_{s=1}^{t} \mathbb{I}\{A_s = i\}\, X_s.$$

$T_i(t)$ is the number of pulls of arm i up to time t and $\hat{\mu}_i(t)$ is the estimated (empirical mean) reward of arm i.

Definition 17 (Explore-then-Commit (ETC))**.** Let k be the number of arms and $m \in \mathbb{N}$ a parameter: the number of exploration pulls *per arm* (so mk pulls overall).
Explore-then-Commit(m):

for $t = 1, \ldots, n$:

$$A_t = \begin{cases} (t \bmod k) + 1 & \text{if } t \le mk \quad \text{(explore)} \\ \arg\max_i \hat{\mu}_i(mk) & \text{if } t > mk \quad \text{(commit)} \end{cases}$$

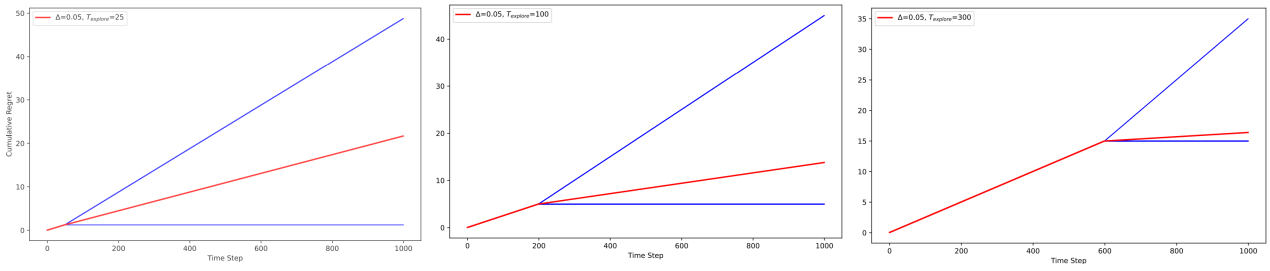
Remark 11.
- The only parameter to set is the number of exploration steps: m per arm, mk overall (the duration of the explore phase).
- The *order* of pulls in the explore phase does not matter, it just needs to be m per arm. One could pull arm 1 m times back-to-back, then arm 2, etc.
- The algorithm itself is generic, but the *analysis* will need to assume subgaussian rewards for all arms.
- After time mk the estimates are frozen, so the arm played from $mk + 1$ to n is the same one at every step (ties broken arbitrarily).

0.5.2 Simulations: Bernoulli bandit with $k = 2$

To build intuition, we look at simulations on a Bernoulli bandit with $k = 2$ arms and suboptimality gap $\Delta = \mu_1 - \mu_2$. In the plots, the **blue** curves are individual trajectories of $\sum_{a \in \mathcal{A}} \Delta_a T_a(t)$, the trajectory-dependent (random) regret, while the **red** curve is $R_n = \sum_{a \in \mathcal{A}} \Delta_a \, \mathbb{E}[T_a(t)]$, the expected regret.

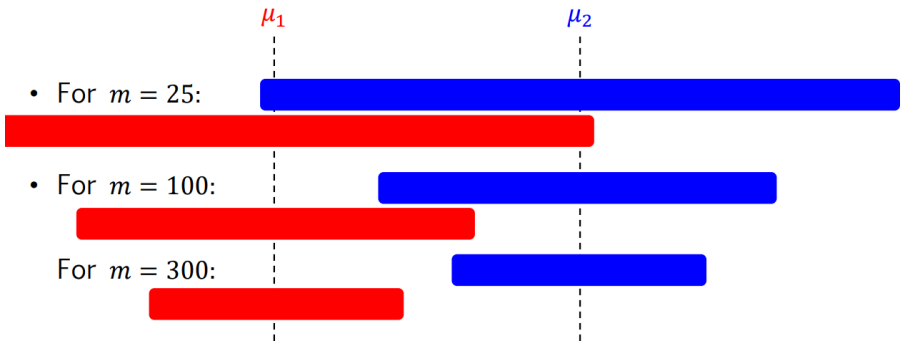
Small gap $\Delta = 0.05$

- **Small** $m = 25$: exploration is cheap but the estimates are noisy, so many trajectories commit to the wrong arm and keep paying linear regret afterwards.
- **Medium** $m = 100$: fewer trajectories fail.
- **Large** $m = 300$: the expected regret is close to its minimum: most trajectories find the right arm and incur no further regret after $t = mk$. The confidence intervals of μ_1 and μ_2 have almost no overlap.



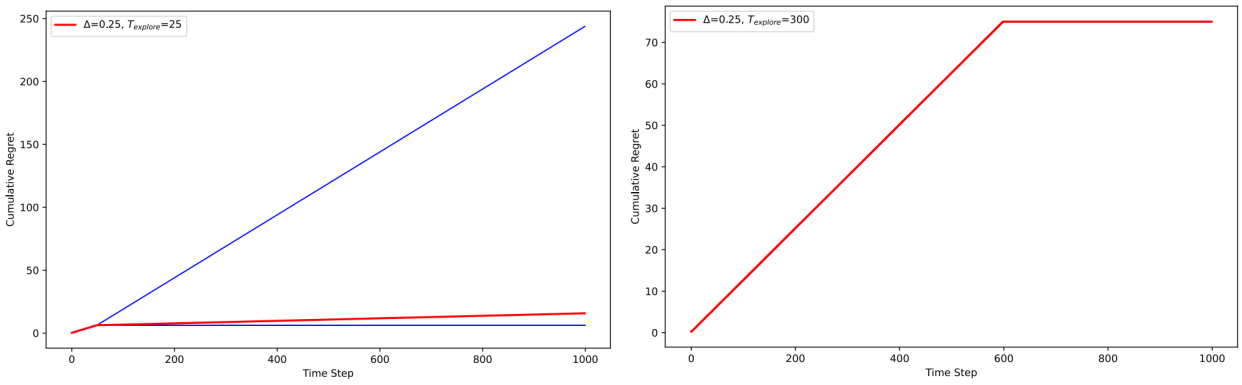
Confidence intervals of the per-arm reward

Recall the confidence interval $\left[\hat{\mu} - \sqrt{\frac{2\sigma^2 \ln(2/\delta)}{m}},\ \hat{\mu} + \sqrt{\frac{2\sigma^2 \ln(2/\delta)}{m}}\right]$ after m pulls. As m grows ($m = 25$, 100, 300), the intervals around μ_1 and μ_2 shrink until they no longer overlap: the algorithm can then tell the arms apart reliably.



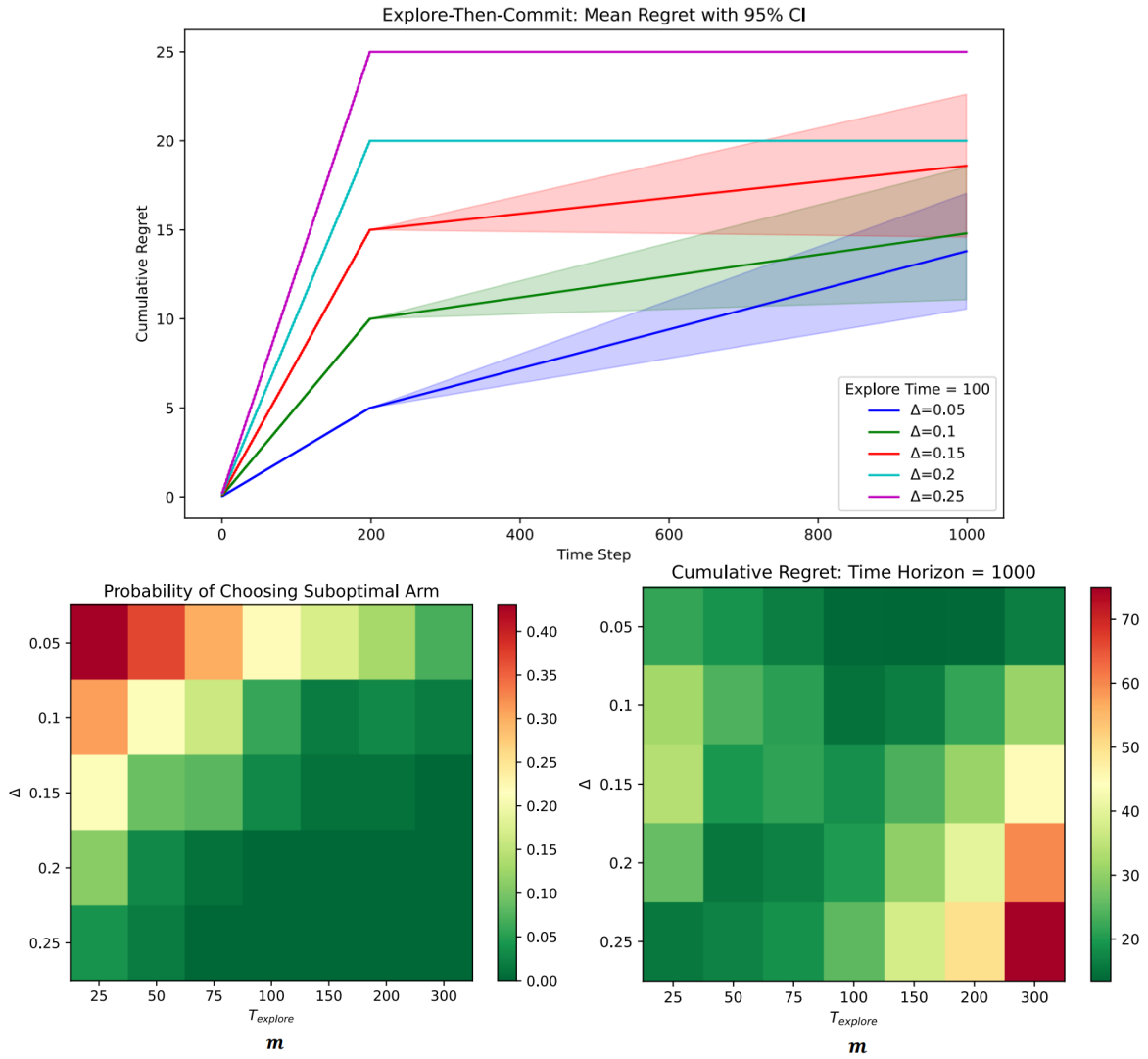
Large gap $\Delta = 0.25$

- **Small** $m = 25$: a larger Δ means the winning arm is more likely to be the better arm, even with few samples.
- **Large** $m = 300$: no more failures in the simulation.



Effect of Δ and m

- **Cumulative regret** R_n **for different** Δ **(fixed** $m = 100$**)**: a larger Δ means more costly exploration (each pull of the bad arm costs Δ), but less risky exploitation (the wrong arm is rarely selected).
- $\mathbb{P}$**(wrong arm at time** n**) as a function of** Δ **and** m: increasing m helps finding the optimal arm; this is made harder by a smaller Δ.
- **Cumulative regret** R_n **as a function of** Δ **and** m: there is a tradeoff. For small Δ one needs a large m; for large Δ a small m suffices. Intermediate Δ gives a higher regret than both the small and the large Δ regimes.



0.5.3 Regret bound for ETC with 1-subgaussian rewards

Theorem 8 (Regret of ETC). *For ETC on a 1-subgaussian bandit (all arms have 1-subgaussian reward noise), for $n \geq mk$,*

$$R_n \leq \underbrace{m \sum_{i=1}^{k} \Delta_i}_{\text{exploration}} + \underbrace{(n - mk) \sum_{i=1}^{k} \Delta_i \exp\left(-\frac{m\Delta_i^2}{4}\right)}_{\text{exploitation}}.$$

Proof. Assume without loss of generality that $\mu_1 = \mu^* = \max_i \mu_i$ (so $\Delta_1 = 0$). By the regret decomposition lemma (previous lecture),

$$R_n = \sum_{i=1}^{k} \Delta_i \, \mathbb{E}[T_i(n)].$$

Arm i is pulled exactly m times during exploration; afterwards, it is pulled at each of the $n - mk$ remaining steps if and only if it was selected at time $mk + 1$. Hence

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}[T_i(n)] &= m + (n - mk)\, \mathbb{P}\big(A_{mk+1} = i\big) \\ &\leq m + (n - mk)\, \mathbb{P}\Big(\hat{\mu}_i(mk) \geq \max_{j \neq i} \hat{\mu}_j(mk)\Big). \end{aligned}$$

Now, for $i \neq 1$, the event that i beats *all* other arms is contained in the event that it beats arm 1:

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbb{P}\Big(\hat{\mu}_i(mk) \geq \max_{j\neq i} \hat{\mu}_j(mk)\Big) &\leq \mathbb{P}\big(\hat{\mu}_i(mk) \geq \hat{\mu}_1(mk)\big) \\ &= \mathbb{P}\Big(\big(\hat{\mu}_i(mk) - \mu_i\big) - \big(\hat{\mu}_1(mk) - \mu_1\big) \geq \Delta_i\Big).\end{aligned}$$

The empirical mean $\hat{\mu}_i(mk)$ is computed from m i.i.d. samples: $m\hat{\mu}_i - m\mu_i$ is a sum of m independent 1-subgaussian variables, hence $m\hat{\mu}_i(mk)$ is $\sqrt{m}$-subgaussian, so $\hat{\mu}_i(mk) - \mu_i$ is $1/\sqrt{m}$-subgaussian. The two arms are sampled independently, so the difference $\big(\hat{\mu}_i - \mu_i\big) - \big(\hat{\mu}_1 - \mu_1\big)$ is $\sqrt{2/m}$-subgaussian. The tail bound then gives

$$\mathbb{P}\Big(\big(\hat{\mu}_i - \mu_i\big) - \big(\hat{\mu}_1 - \mu_1\big) \geq \Delta_i\Big) \leq \exp\left(-\frac{\Delta_i^2}{2 \cdot (2/m)}\right) = \exp\left(-\frac{m\Delta_i^2}{4}\right).$$

Plugging everything back into $R_n = \sum_i \Delta_i \, \mathbb{E}[T_i(n)]$ gives the claim. □

Remark 12 (Tradeoff)**.**
- m large ⇒ exploration is costly (first term grows linearly in m);
- m small ⇒ potential to bet on the wrong arm forever (second term is large, it is multiplied by $n - mk$).

This is exactly the explore-exploit tradeoff, now quantified.

0.5.4 Analysis for $k = 2$

Assume again that the first arm is optimal: $\Delta_1 = 0$, and write $\Delta_2 = \Delta$. The bound for general k becomes

$$R_n \leq m\Delta + (n - 2m)\Delta \exp\left(-\frac{m\Delta^2}{4}\right) \leq m\Delta + n\Delta \exp\left(-\frac{m\Delta^2}{4}\right).$$

Which m minimizes this quantity? Differentiating the right-hand side with respect to m:

$$\Delta - n\Delta \cdot \frac{\Delta^2}{4} \exp\left(-\frac{m\Delta^2}{4}\right) = 0 \iff \exp\left(-\frac{m\Delta^2}{4}\right) = \frac{4}{n\Delta^2},$$

so (ignoring rounding)

$$m = \frac{4}{\Delta^2} \ln\left(\frac{n\Delta^2}{4}\right).$$

The resulting regret bound is of the form

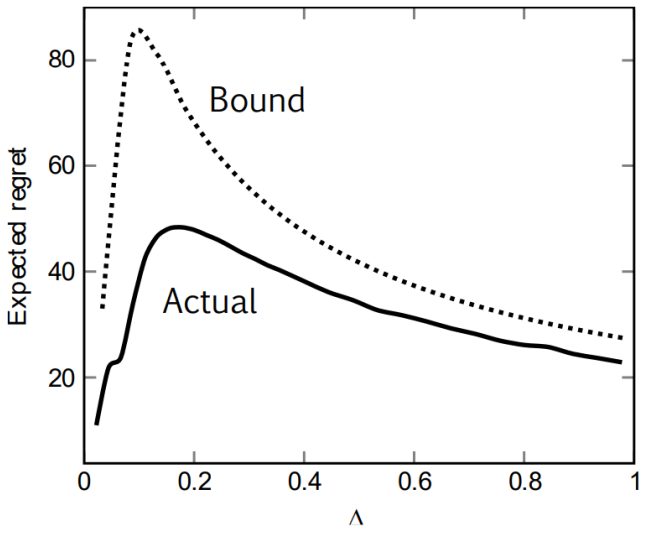
$$R_n \leq \Delta + C\sqrt{n},$$

for a universal constant C.

- Without an assumption on Δ, we cannot avoid potentially infinite regret (a single bad pull can cost arbitrarily much). Within a bandit class such that $\Delta \leq 1$: $R_n \leq 1 + C\sqrt{n}$.
- Replacing Δ by a value result in an example of a **worst-case** (or **problem-independent**) bound: it does not depend on the specific environment instance ν, only on the environment class (here: subgaussian and $\Delta \leq 1$) and on the horizon n.
- **But**: to set the correct m, we do need to know Δ "ahead of time". Can we have a universal algorithm that does well for unknown Δ, i.e., that decides *adaptively* when we have explored enough? (This motivates the algorithms of the next lectures.)

0.5.5 Comparison of the bound with simulations

The bound is relatively loose (due to approximations in the proof) for intermediate suboptimality gaps Δ, but pretty good for larger Δ. It slightly underestimates the critical Δ (the gap at which the actual regret peaks).



0.6 Summary

- **Convergence of random variables**: for sums of i.i.d. variables, the law of large numbers and the central limit theorem describe the asymptotic behavior. Markov and Chebyshev give finite-n bounds, but they are too loose ($1/n$).
- **Tail bound for finite** n: the large deviation (Chernoff-type) bound $\mathbb{P}(\hat{\mu} \geq \mu+\epsilon) \leq \exp(-n\epsilon^2/(2\sigma^2))$, valid for subgaussian noise, and the resulting confidence intervals of width $\sqrt{2\sigma^2 \ln(2/\delta)/n}$.
- **Subgaussian distributions**: "nice" noise, light tail, "no big excesses". It is a strong condition (even the exponential distribution is too heavy). Properties: scaling (αX is $|\alpha|\sigma$-subgaussian) and independent sums (variance parameters add up). Examples: Gaussian, bounded variables.
- **Explore-then-Commit (ETC)**: explore for a fixed window (m pulls per arm), then exploit forever. Tradeoff between expensive exploration and failed exploitation.
- **Upper bound on** R_n **for the** 1**-subgaussian bandit**: $R_n \leq m\sum_i \Delta_i + (n-mk)\sum_i \Delta_i \exp(-m\Delta_i^2/4)$; for $k=2$ and optimally tuned m, $R_n \leq \Delta + C\sqrt{n}$. Limitation: tuning m requires knowing Δ.

Lecture 4 — 2026-09-30: Adaptive Explore-then-Commit and the Upper Confidence Bound Algorithm

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At the end of the previous lecture, we saw that Explore-then-Commit (ETC) reaches a good regret only if the exploration length m is tuned with the knowledge of the suboptimality gap Δ, which is unknown in practice. This lecture answers the question raised there: *can we decide adaptively, from the data, when we have explored enough?* We first make ETC adaptive using confidence intervals, extend it to $k > 2$ arms (sequential elimination), and then introduce the main algorithm of the lecture: the **Upper Confidence Bound (UCB)** algorithm, which is based on the principle of *optimism in the face of uncertainty.*

0.7 Recap

0.7.1 Multi-armed bandits

- **Problem setup**: k arms, each arm generates random rewards. Arm i has reward distribution P_i with mean μ_i; the best arm has mean $\mu^* = \max_i \mu_i$. The reward distributions are *unknown* to the learner at the beginning.
- **Algorithm**: at time t, take action $A_t \in \{1, 2, \dots, k\}$, observe the reward $X_t \sim P_{A_t}$, and continue for $t = 1, 2, \dots, n$. This is a sequential decision-making process: A_t may depend on all the past actions and rewards.
- **Goal**: achieve *sublinear* regret, i.e., eventually pull the best arm (almost) every time.

0.7.2 Regret

- **Instantaneous regret** at round t: $r_t = \mu^* - \mu_{A_t} = \Delta_{A_t}$. It measures the (expected) suboptimality of arm A_t: bad arm $\Leftrightarrow$ large regret, good arm $\Leftrightarrow$ small regret, best arm $\Leftrightarrow$ zero regret.
- **Cumulative regret**: $R_n = \sum_{t=1}^{n} \mathbb{E}[r_t]$.
- **Regret decomposition**: $R_n = \sum_{t=1}^{n} \mathbb{E}[r_t] = \sum_{a \in \mathcal{A}} \Delta_a \, \mathbb{E}[T_a(n)]$.
- Sublinear cumulative regret $\Leftrightarrow$ vanishing instantaneous regret.

Hence, to minimize regret, we must eliminate bad arms quickly and eventually identify (and keep pulling) the best arm(s). The difficulty: due to randomness, we can *never* identify good and bad arms with certainty.

0.7.3 Explore-then-Commit

- **Overview**: explore (round robin) until a fixed time mk; this gives an estimate $\hat{\mu}_i$ of μ_i for every arm i. If $\hat{\mu}_i \approx \mu_i$, picking $i^* = \arg\max_i \hat{\mu}_i$ identifies the best arm. Then commit to (keep pulling) i^* for rounds $mk + 1$ to n.
- **Intuition**: if the best arm is correctly identified, there is no regret during the commit phase, so $R_n \propto m$: great! If a suboptimal arm is chosen, we pay a constant positive regret at all remaining rounds, so $R_n \propto n$: bad!
- **Tradeoff**: very short exploration $\Rightarrow |\hat{\mu}_i - \mu_i|$ large $\Rightarrow$ likely to choose a suboptimal arm $\Rightarrow$ large regret. Very long exploration $\Rightarrow$ excessive exploration $\Rightarrow$ large regret.

0.8 Adaptive Explore-then-Commit

0.8.1 Idea: the exploration length as a stopping time

Key idea: think of m as a **stopping time**.

- m is now *random* and can depend on past data.
- It signals when to stop exploring and start exploiting.
- Ideally, we stop as soon as we are sufficiently confident about which arm is optimal.

With a *fixed* m, two things can go wrong:

- we may still not be sure about the optimal arm at time mk (**under-exploration**);
- or we may have been very sure about the optimal arm much earlier (**over-exploration**).

Idea: decide when to stop by looking at the data. Keep pulling all arms equally often and computing the $\hat{\mu}_i$, until we are (reasonably) certain that one arm is better than all the others. How do we quantify certainty? With **confidence intervals**!

0.8.2 Confidence intervals

Let $X_1, X_2, \ldots, X_n$ be i.i.d. samples of a random variable with unknown mean μ, and $\hat{\mu}_n = \frac{1}{n}\sum_i X_i$ the estimate of μ. Typically, $\hat{\mu}_n$ is close to μ, but not exactly equal to it. What we can say is

$$|\hat{\mu}_n - \mu| \leq \epsilon \quad \text{with probability at least } 1-\delta,$$

or equivalently, $\mu \in [\hat{\mu}_n - \epsilon, \hat{\mu}_n + \epsilon]$ with high probability. There are two quantities in this statement: the **confidence interval** (half-width ϵ) and the **confidence level** (error probability δ).

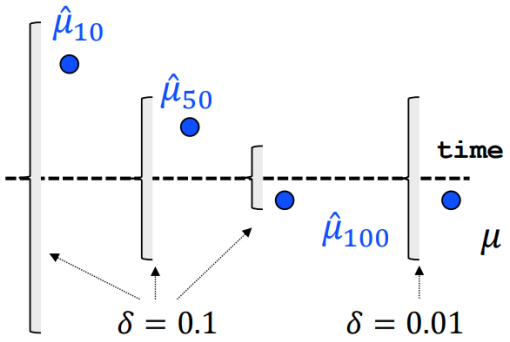
If the $X_i - \mu$ are σ-subgaussian (with the abuse of notation of the previous lecture, we simply say that the X_i are σ-subgaussian), the concentration inequality of the previous lecture gives

$$\mathbb{P}\big(|\hat{\mu}_n - \mu| \geq \epsilon\big) \leq 2\exp\left(-\frac{n\epsilon^2}{2\sigma^2}\right) =: \delta.$$

- Given ϵ, we can compute δ with this inequality; alternatively, we fix δ and compute ϵ:

$$\epsilon = \sigma\sqrt{\frac{2\ln(2/\delta)}{n}}, \qquad \text{or equivalently} \qquad n = \frac{2\sigma^2\ln(2/\delta)}{\epsilon^2}.$$

- For fixed δ, ϵ decreases as n increases (as $1/\sqrt{n}$).
- For fixed n, ϵ decreases as δ increases (we accept a larger error probability in exchange for a tighter interval).
- ϵ grows linearly with the subgaussian parameter σ: noisier rewards need more samples ($n \propto \sigma^2$) for the same precision.

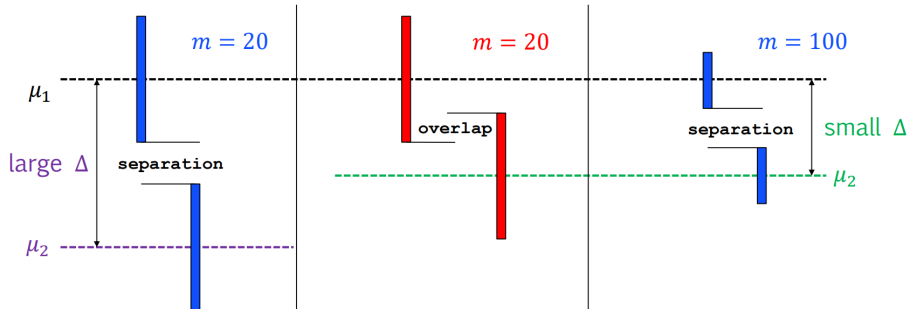


0.8.3 Using confidence intervals to decide when to commit

How can we confidently decide when one arm is better than the other?

- Pretend that each arm's mean reward lies in its confidence interval *with certainty.*
- If the confidence intervals **overlap**, the best arm is undecided.
- If the confidence intervals are **disjoint**, the best arm is clear!

Strategy: keep exploring until the confidence intervals separate.



This makes m **data-dependent**:

- With sufficient exploration, the confidence intervals eventually separate (their width goes to 0 as $1/\sqrt{m}$).
- When $\mu_1 - \mu_2$ is large, the confidence intervals separate early, so $\mathbb{E}[m]$ is small.
- When $\mu_1 - \mu_2$ is small, the confidence intervals separate only after a long time, so $\mathbb{E}[m]$ is large.

The exploration time is chosen from the data, not fixed a priori.

Definition 18 (Upper and lower confidence bounds)**.** For an arm with n samples and empirical mean $\hat{\mu}_n$, starting from $\mathbb{P}\big(|\hat{\mu}_n - \mu| \geq \epsilon\big) \leq 2\exp\big(-n\epsilon^2/(2\sigma^2)\big)$ and solving for ϵ:

$$UCB(n,\delta) = \hat{\mu}_n + \sigma\sqrt{\frac{2\ln(2/\delta)}{n}}, \qquad LCB(n,\delta) = \hat{\mu}_n - \sigma\sqrt{\frac{2\ln(2/\delta)}{n}}.$$

UCB is the **Upper Confidence Bound** ($\hat{\mu} + \epsilon$), LCB the **Lower Confidence Bound** ($\hat{\mu} - \epsilon$). With probability at least $1 - \delta$, $\mu \in [LCB(n,\delta), UCB(n,\delta)]$.

0.8.4 Algorithm

Definition 19 (Adaptive ETC (ETC with confidence intervals))**.** Hyperparameters: confidence level $\delta \in (0,1)$ and a minimum number of pulls per arm m_0.

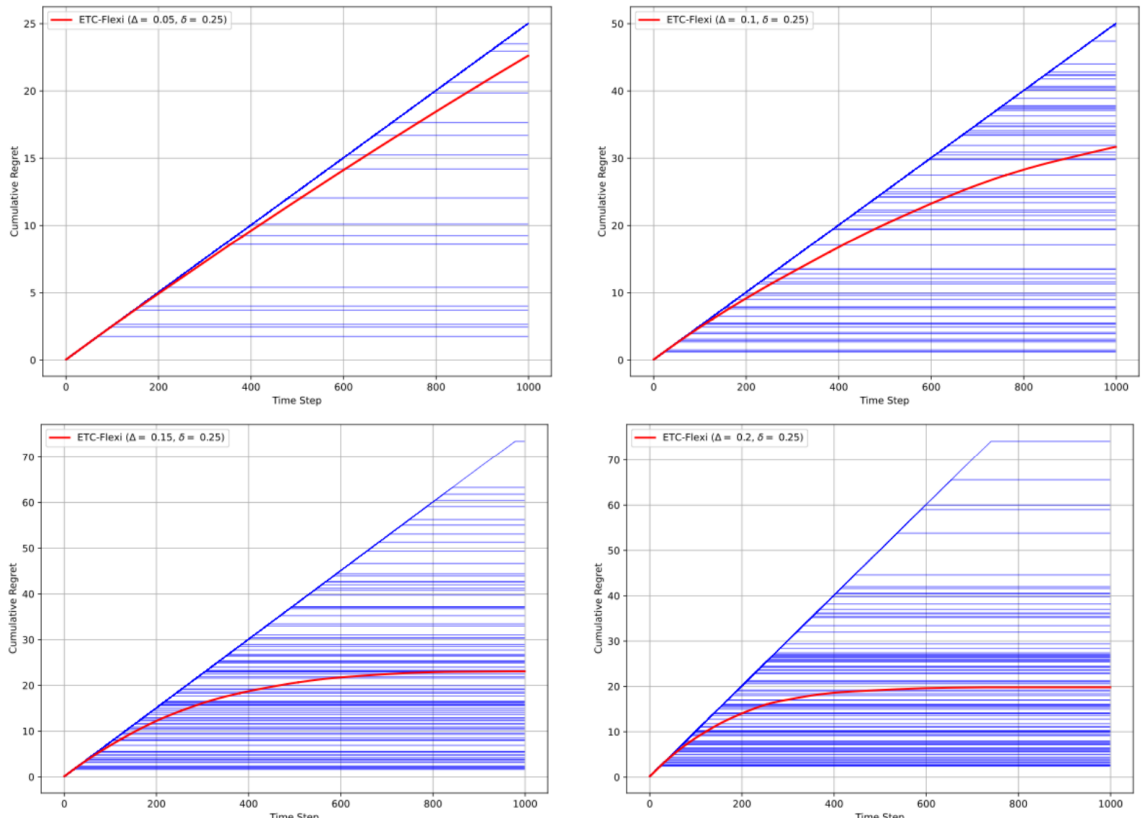
Initialize: $T_a(0) = 0$, $\hat{\mu}_a(0) = 0$ for all arms $a \in \mathcal{A}$; `committed_arm` = `None`.
for $t = 1, 2, \ldots, n$ **do**:
  if `committed_arm` $\neq$ `None`: $A_t =$ `committed_arm`
  else: $A_t = (t \bmod k) + 1$
    check for commitment if $t \geq m_0 k$:
      compute $\hat{\mu}_a(t)$ for all $a \in \mathcal{A}$, and $a_t^* = \arg\max_a \hat{\mu}_a(t)$;
      compute $UCB_a(t,\delta)$ and $LCB_a(t,\delta)$ for all $a \in \mathcal{A}$;
      if $LCB_{a_t^*}(t,\delta) > UCB_a(t,\delta)$ for all $a \neq a_t^*$: `committed_arm` $= a_t^*$.

Here $UCB_a(t,\delta)$ and $LCB_a(t,\delta)$ are the bounds of arm a computed with its $T_a(t)$ samples.

Remark 13.
- The commitment rule is exactly "the confidence interval of the empirically best arm is entirely above the confidence intervals of all other arms".

- m_0 forces every arm to be sampled a minimum number of times before any commitment is even considered.
- Compared to ETC, the only parameter is now δ (and m_0); no knowledge of Δ is needed.

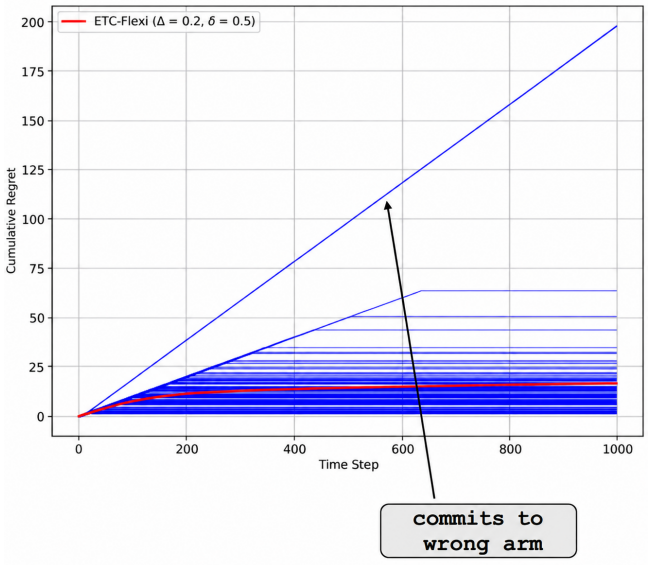
0.8.5 Simulations



Salient features:

- The exploration period is random (each trajectory commits at a different time).
- The expected cumulative regret is sublinear.
- Larger $\Delta \Rightarrow$ the algorithm commits earlier.
- As for fixed ETC, the regret is highest for moderate Δ (here $\Delta = 0.1$): small Δ makes mistakes cheap, large Δ makes the arms easy to distinguish.

Importance of the hyperparameter δ



- **Very small** $\delta \Rightarrow$ wide intervals, too conservative: over-exploration.
- **Very large** $\delta \Rightarrow$ narrow intervals, too optimistic: some trajectories commit to the wrong arm, and then pay linear regret.
- **Rule of thumb**: the larger the horizon n, the smaller δ should be, because a mistaken commitment costs regret at each of the (many) remaining rounds.

Remark 14. A wrong commitment costs up to $\Delta \cdot n$, and happens with a probability of order δ. If δ stays fixed while n grows, this term is linear in n; this is why δ must decrease with n (we will see the choice $\delta = 1/n^2$ for UCB).

0.9 More than two arms: Sequential Elimination

0.9.1 ETC for $k > 2$ arms

How can we extend the (adaptive) ETC principle to multi-armed bandits? As for two arms, we need to pull each arm a few times to estimate its reward: exploration of all arms is necessary. With more exploration, the confidence interval of each arm keeps shrinking; eventually the intervals become disjoint and the best arm becomes clear.

There are two different interpretations of ETC for $k > 2$:

- **View 1**: keep exploring until the best arm is identified. Commit to arm i once its confidence interval dominates the confidence intervals of *all* other arms.
- **View 2**: keep eliminating arms that are clearly not the best. If the confidence interval of some arm i dominates that of arm j (i.e. $LCB_i > UCB_j$), stop pulling arm j.

The two views are **equivalent with two arms**, but **different in the multi-armed case**!

0.9.2 From ETC to sequential elimination

Algorithm from View 1 (adaptive ETC): all arms are pulled equally often until the commit time mk. Likely behavior: the worse arms clearly separate out long before the competitive ones do, but we keep pulling them anyway. This is wasteful exploration on bad arms, hence a large regret.

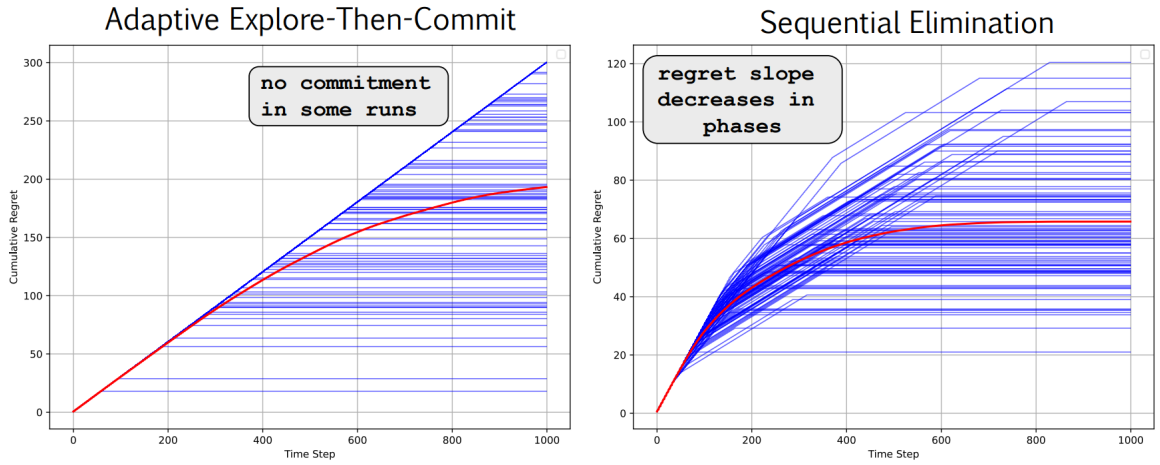
Algorithm from View 2: **Sequential Elimination (SE)**.

- Initially, all arms are pulled in round robin.
- The algorithm proceeds in *phases*, eliminating one arm per phase: a phase ends when the confidence interval of some remaining arm becomes dominated by that of another remaining arm; the dominated arm is removed and the round robin continues on the remaining ones.
- The length of each phase is random.
- The instantaneous regret decreases from phase to phase (the worst arms are removed first).
- Eventually, we are left with only the best arm.

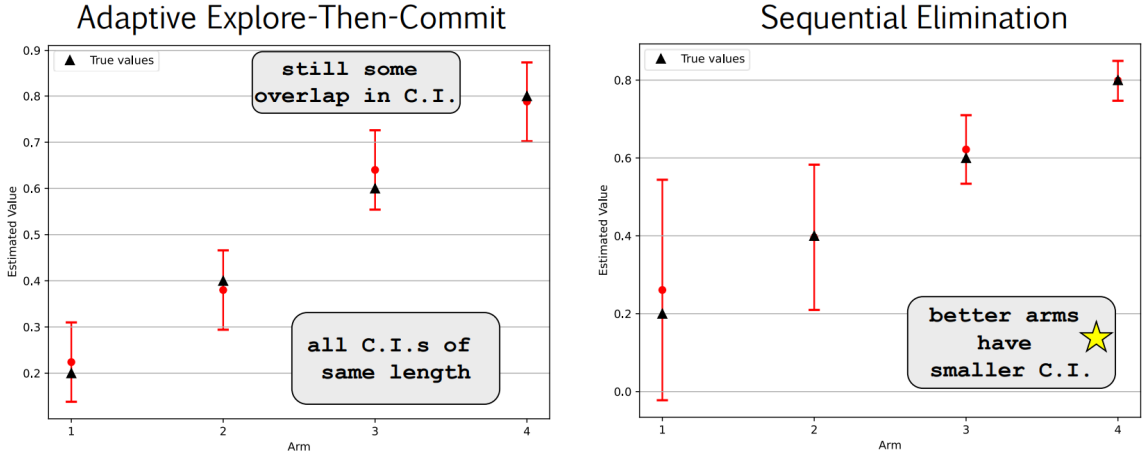
Sequential elimination is the "right" extension of ETC to multi-armed bandits.

0.9.3 Simulations: adaptive ETC versus sequential elimination

Setting: 4-armed Bernoulli bandit with mean rewards $[0.2, 0.4, 0.6, 0.8]$.



- **Regret**: with adaptive ETC, there is no commitment at all in some runs (within the horizon), so the regret keeps growing linearly for those runs. With SE, the regret slope decreases in phases, each time an arm is eliminated.



- **Confidence intervals**: with adaptive ETC, all confidence intervals have the same length (all arms are pulled equally often), and there can still be some overlap between the competitive arms.

With SE, the better arms have smaller confidence intervals: the remaining samples are spent on the arms that still matter.

0.10 The Upper Confidence Bound (UCB) algorithm

0.10.1 Algorithm

UCB is a very popular algorithm for multi-armed bandits. It uses confidence bounds, like adaptive ETC and sequential elimination, but in a different way, which leads to better regret in practice.

Notation ("at time t" means after t overall pulls):

- $\hat{\mu}_a(t)$: estimate of the mean reward of arm a at time t;
- $T_a(t)$: number of pulls of arm a at time t;
- upper confidence bound of arm a at time t (assuming 1-subgaussian rewards):

$$UCB_a(t,\delta) = \hat{\mu}_a(t) + \sqrt{\frac{2\ln(1/\delta)}{T_a(t)}},$$

with $UCB_a(t,\delta) = \infty$ when $T_a(t) = 0$.

Definition 20. (UCB algorithm).

for $t = 1, 2, \ldots, n$ **do**:
choose $A_t = \arg\max_a UCB_a(t-1,\delta)$;
observe X_t and update $UCB_a(t,\delta)$.

Remark 15.
- Since $UCB_a = \infty$ initially, every arm is pulled once during the first k rounds.
- Here the bound is *one-sided* (only the upper bound matters), hence $\ln(1/\delta)$ instead of $\ln(2/\delta)$; and $\sigma = 1$. By the concentration inequality, for a fixed number s of samples, $\mathbb{P}\big(\mu \geq \hat{\mu}_s + \sqrt{2\ln(1/\delta)/s}\big) \leq \delta$.
- Unlike ETC, there are no separate phases: the same rule is applied at every round.

0.10.2 Exploration-exploitation tradeoff in UCB

The UCB index is the sum of two terms:

$$UCB_a(t,\delta) = \underbrace{\hat{\mu}_a(t)}_{\text{empirical mean}} + \underbrace{\sqrt{\frac{2\ln(1/\delta)}{T_a(t)}}}_{\text{exploration bonus}}.$$

The algorithm pulls an arm more often if it is

- either **promising**: its empirical mean $\hat{\mu}_a(t)$ is large (exploitation);
- or **not well explored**: $T_a(t)$ is small, so the exploration bonus is large (exploration).

Why is this a reasonable strategy?

- With high probability, $UCB_{a^*}(t,\delta) > \mu_{a^*}$ at all times.
- If a suboptimal arm $a \neq a^*$ is pulled, then $UCB_a(t,\delta) > UCB_{a^*}(t,\delta)$.
- With enough pulls, $UCB_a(t,\delta) \approx \mu_a$, and $\mu_a < \mu_{a^*} < UCB_{a^*}(t,\delta)$, so a stops being chosen.
- Hence suboptimal arms are not pulled too many times! Heuristically, arm a stops being pulled once its bonus is smaller than its gap, $\sqrt{2\ln(1/\delta)/T_a} \lesssim \Delta_a$, i.e. after about $T_a \approx 2\ln(1/\delta)/\Delta_a^2$ pulls. The regret bound below makes this precise.

0.10.3 Optimism in the face of uncertainty: UCB versus ETC

UCB follows the **Optimism in the Face of Uncertainty (OFU)** principle:

- UCB plays assuming the arm rewards are the highest they can reasonably be, i.e., it pretends $\mu_a = UCB_a(t, \delta)$ (the top of the confidence interval).

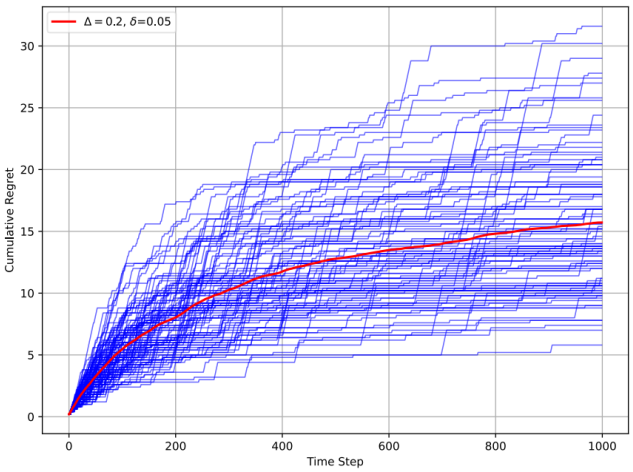
ETC (and sequential elimination) is more **conservative**: it takes a worst-case approach, where arm rewards could be anything in their respective confidence intervals.

- It only commits to the best arm if it is "sure" that it is the best: its confidence interval must dominate all the others.
- Likewise, it only eliminates a bad arm if it is "sure" that this arm is not the best.

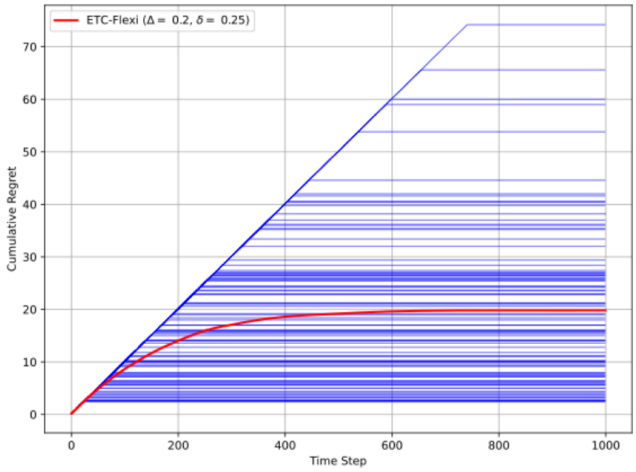
Transition from exploration to exploitation:

- UCB has a **soft** transition: exploration gradually fades out but never stops completely.
- ETC has a **hard** transition: explore phase versus commit phase. If one makes a mistake (commits to or eliminates the wrong arm), it is difficult (impossible) to correct it.

0.10.4 Simulations



UCB Algorithm



ETC Algorithm (with flexible stopping time)

Points to note:

- For each sample path, the regret growth (slope) decays gently with time; contrast with ETC, where each trajectory has a kink at the commitment time and is flat (or linear, if the commitment was wrong) afterwards.
- Exploration never stops completely.
- The mean regret is sublinear. What is its growth rate: $O(\sqrt{n})$? $O(\ln n)$? This is answered by the theorem below: $O(\ln n)$ for a fixed instance.

0.11 Regret bound for UCB

Theorem 9 (Regret of UCB)**.** *Consider the UCB algorithm applied to a stochastic* 1*-subgaussian bandit with* k *arms, with error tolerance* $\delta = 1/n^2$*. Then the regret satisfies*

$$R_n \leq 3\sum_{i=1}^{k} \Delta_i + \sum_{i:\Delta_i>0} \frac{16 \ln n}{\Delta_i}.$$

Remark 16.

- The regret is **logarithmic** in n: much better than the $\sqrt{n}$ worst-case behavior of ETC.
- It is a **problem-dependent** bound: it depends on the gaps Δ_i of the instance. It blows up as $\Delta_i \to 0$, but arms with tiny gaps also cost little per pull.
- Unlike ETC, the algorithm does **not** need to know the gaps: the only parameter is δ, which depends only on n.

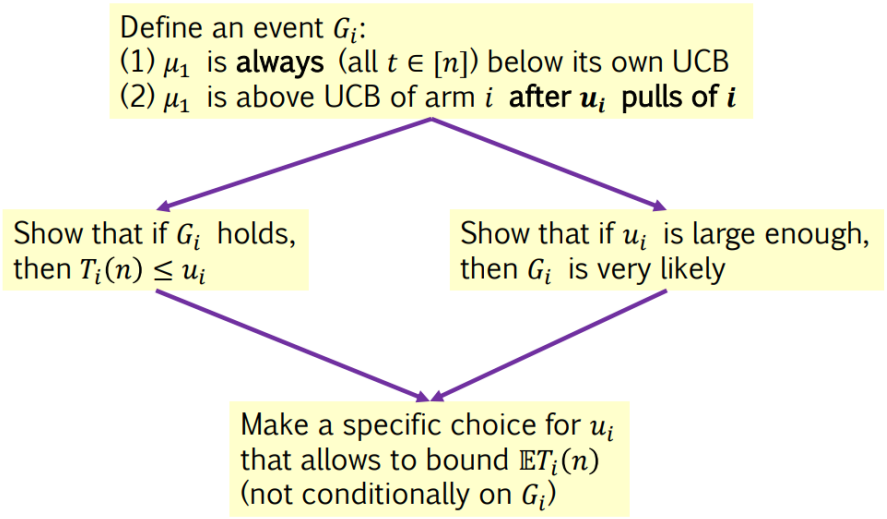
0.11.1 Proof outline

Assume without loss of generality that arm 1 is optimal ($\mu_1 = \mu^*$). By the regret decomposition $R_n = \sum_i \Delta_i \mathbb{E}[T_i(n)]$, it suffices to show that, for every suboptimal arm i,

$$\mathbb{E}[T_i(n)] \leq 3 + \frac{16 \ln n}{\Delta_i^2}.$$

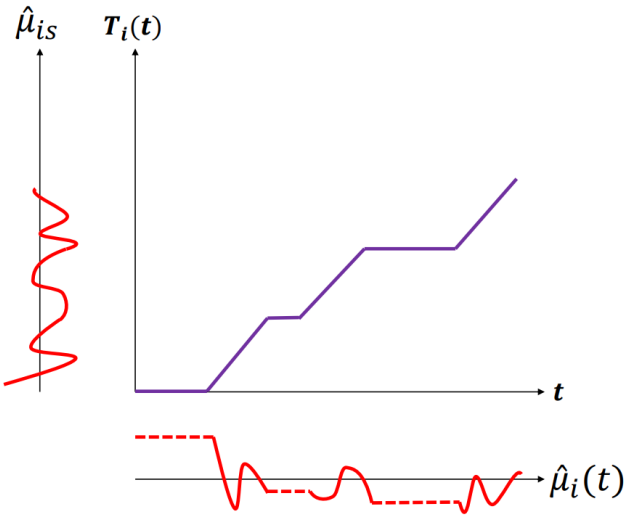
Multiplying by Δ_i and summing over i gives the theorem.

The proof proceeds in four steps:



0.11.2 Notation: $\hat{\mu}_i(t)$ versus $\hat{\mu}_{is}$

- $\hat{\mu}_i(t)$: estimator of the mean of arm i at *time* t.
- $\hat{\mu}_{is}$: estimator after s *pulls* of arm i, i.e., the average of the first s i.i.d. samples of arm i.
- They are related by $\hat{\mu}_i(t) = \hat{\mu}_{iT_i(t)}$. Remember that $T_i(t) \leq t$ for all t.



Remark 17 (Why this distinction matters)**.** $T_i(t)$ is random and depends on the past rewards, so $\hat{\mu}_i(t)$ is *not* an average of a fixed number of i.i.d. samples, and the concentration inequality cannot be applied to it directly. In contrast, $\hat{\mu}_{is}$, for a *fixed* s, is an average of s i.i.d. 1-subgaussian samples, so $\hat{\mu}_{is} - \mu_i$ is $1/\sqrt{s}$-subgaussian. The proof therefore works with $\hat{\mu}_{is}$, and handles all possible values of s with a union bound.

0.11.3 Step 1: the good event

Definition 21 (Good event)**.** For a suboptimal arm i and an integer u_i (to be chosen), let

$$G_i = \left\{\mu_1 < \min_{t\in[n]} UCB_1(t,\delta)\right\} \cap \left\{\hat{\mu}_{iu_i} + \sqrt{\frac{2}{u_i}\ln\frac{1}{\delta}} < \mu_1\right\}.$$

The first event says that μ_1 always stays inside its confidence interval (more precisely: below its UCB). The second says that once arm i has been pulled u_i times, its UCB does not exceed μ_1.

Bound on $\mathbb{E}[T_i(n)]$. Splitting on G_i and using $T_i(n) \leq u_i$ on G_i (step 2) and $T_i(n) \leq n$ always:

$$\mathbb{E}[T_i(n)] = \mathbb{E}\big[\mathbb{I}\{G_i\}\, T_i(n)\big] + \mathbb{E}\big[\mathbb{I}\{G_i^c\}\, T_i(n)\big] \leq u_i + \mathbb{P}(G_i^c)\, n.$$

We will need to choose u_i wisely, because there is a tradeoff:

- u_i too large $\Rightarrow$ the first term, hence the regret bound, is too large;
- u_i too small $\Rightarrow$ $\mathbb{P}(G_i^c)$ is too large $\Rightarrow$ the second term, hence the regret bound, is too large.

0.11.4 Step 2: on G_i, $T_i(n) \le u_i$

Lemma 4. *If G_i holds, then $T_i(n) \le u_i$.*

Proof. By contradiction: assume G_i holds and $T_i(n) > u_i$. Then arm i was pulled more than u_i times before n, so there must be a round t at which arm i was pulled for the (u_i+1)-th time; at that round, $T_i(t-1) = u_i$. We use this to relate UCB_i to UCB_1:

$$\begin{aligned} UCB_i(t-1,\delta) &= \hat{\mu}_i(t-1) + \sqrt{\frac{2\ln(1/\delta)}{T_i(t-1)}} \\ &= \hat{\mu}_{iu_i} + \sqrt{\frac{2}{u_i}\ln\frac{1}{\delta}} && \text{since } T_i(t-1) = u_i \\ &< \mu_1 && \text{by definition of } G_i \text{ (second event)} \\ &< UCB_1(t-1,\delta) && \text{by definition of } G_i \text{ (first event).} \end{aligned}$$

So arm 1 had a strictly larger UCB than arm i at time $t-1$, and UCB could not have chosen $A_t = i$: contradiction. □

0.11.5 Step 3: G_i is likely if u_i is large enough

By De Morgan,

$$G_i^c = \left\{\mu_1 \ge \min_{t\in[n]} UCB_1(t,\delta)\right\} \cup \left\{\hat{\mu}_{iu_i} + \sqrt{\frac{2}{u_i}\ln\frac{1}{\delta}} \ge \mu_1\right\},$$

and we bound the probability of each event separately.

First event: μ_1 exceeds its own UCB at some time

At any time t, $UCB_1(t,\delta) = \hat{\mu}_{1s} + \sqrt{\frac{2}{s}\ln\frac{1}{\delta}}$ with $s = T_1(t)$ (and $UCB_1 = \infty$ if $s = 0$). The minimum over $t \in [n]$ only ranges over the values of s actually reached by $T_1(t)$, whereas the minimum over all $s \in [n]$ ranges over all n values; taking the min over more terms can only lower it. Hence

$$\left\{\mu_1 \ge \min_{t\in[n]} UCB_1(t,\delta)\right\} \subseteq \left\{\mu_1 \ge \min_{s\in[n]} \left(\hat{\mu}_{1s} + \sqrt{\frac{2}{s}\ln\frac{1}{\delta}}\right)\right\} = \bigcup_{s\in[n]} \left\{\mu_1 \ge \hat{\mu}_{1s} + \sqrt{\frac{2}{s}\ln\frac{1}{\delta}}\right\}.$$

Using the union bound, then the concentration inequality for the average of s i.i.d. 1-subgaussian samples (confidence interval with error probability δ):

$$\mathbb{P}\left(\mu_1 \ge \min_{t\in[n]} UCB_1(t,\delta)\right) \le \sum_{s=1}^{n} \mathbb{P}\left(\mu_1 \ge \hat{\mu}_{1s} + \sqrt{\frac{2}{s}\ln\frac{1}{\delta}}\right) \le n\delta.$$

Second event: arm i's UCB after u_i pulls is above μ_1

To bound the second event, we need an assumption on u_i: assume u_i is large enough so that

$$\Delta_i - \sqrt{\frac{2\ln(1/\delta)}{u_i}} \geq c\Delta_i \qquad \text{for some constant } 0 < c < 1.$$

Using $\mu_1 = \mu_i + \Delta_i$,

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbb{P}\left(\hat{\mu}_{iu_i} + \sqrt{\frac{2}{u_i}\ln\frac{1}{\delta}} \geq \mu_1\right) &= \mathbb{P}\left(\hat{\mu}_{iu_i} - \mu_i \geq \Delta_i - \sqrt{\frac{2}{u_i}\ln\frac{1}{\delta}}\right) \\ &\leq \mathbb{P}\big(\hat{\mu}_{iu_i} - \mu_i \geq c\Delta_i\big) \\ &\leq \exp\left(-\frac{u_i c^2 \Delta_i^2}{2}\right),\end{aligned}$$

where the last step is the Chernoff bound for subgaussian sums: $\hat{\mu}_{iu_i}$ is the average of u_i terms, so $\hat{\mu}_{iu_i} - \mu_i$ is $1/\sqrt{u_i}$-subgaussian.

Combining

By the union bound,

$$\mathbb{P}(G_i^c) \leq n\delta + \exp\left(-\frac{u_i c^2 \Delta_i^2}{2}\right).$$

0.11.6 Step 4: choice of u_i and conclusion

Back to the bound of step 1:

$$\mathbb{E}[T_i(n)] \leq u_i + \mathbb{P}(G_i^c)\, n \leq u_i + n\left(n\delta + \exp\left(-\frac{u_i c^2 \Delta_i^2}{2}\right)\right).$$

We set u_i as small as possible given the constraint $\Delta_i - \sqrt{2\ln(1/\delta)/u_i} \geq c\Delta_i$, i.e., $\sqrt{2\ln(1/\delta)/u_i} \leq (1-c)\Delta_i$:

$$u_i = \left\lceil \frac{2\ln(1/\delta)}{(1-c)^2\Delta_i^2} \right\rceil.$$

Note that there is no guarantee that $u_i \leq n$; but if it is not, the bound on $\mathbb{E}[T_i(n)]$ holds trivially since $T_i(n) \leq n$.
Recall $\delta = 1/n^2$, so $n \cdot n\delta = 1$ and $\ln(1/\delta) = 2\ln n$. For the exponential term,

$$\exp\left(-\frac{u_i c^2 \Delta_i^2}{2}\right) \leq \exp\left(-\frac{2\ln(1/\delta)\, c^2}{2(1-c)^2}\right) = \exp\left(-\frac{2\ln(n)\, c^2}{(1-c)^2}\right) = n^{-\frac{2c^2}{(1-c)^2}}$$

Therefore

$$\mathbb{E}[T_i(n)] \leq \left\lceil \frac{2\ln(1/\delta)}{(1-c)^2\Delta_i^2} \right\rceil + 1 + n^{1-\frac{2c^2}{(1-c)^2}},$$

We choose c such that the last term does not blow up with n (we need $2c^2 \geq (1-c)^2$, i.e. $c \geq \sqrt{2}-1$); e.g., $c = 1/2$, for which $\frac{2c^2}{(1-c)^2} = 2$ and the last term is $n^{-1} \leq 1$. With $c = 1/2$, $\frac{2\ln(1/\delta)}{(1-c)^2\Delta_i^2} = \frac{4\ln n}{\Delta_i^2/4} = \frac{16\ln n}{\Delta_i^2}$, so

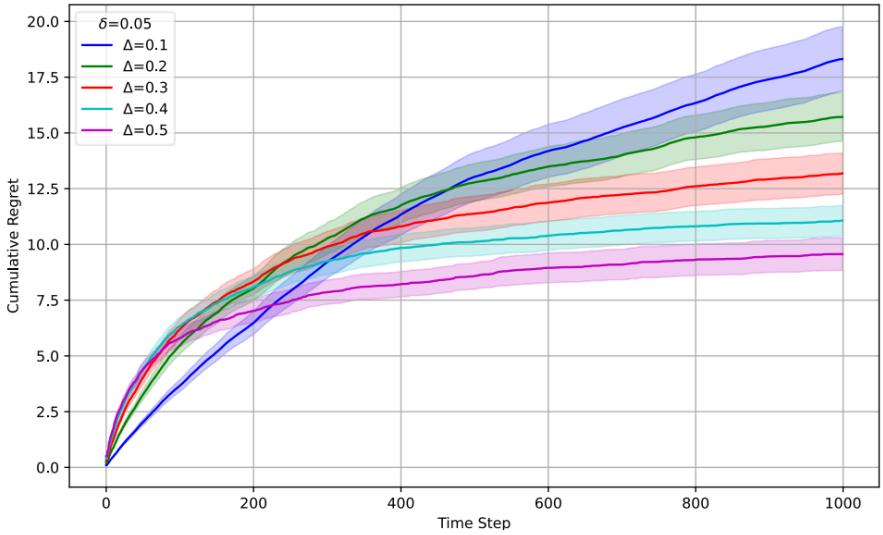
$$\mathbb{E}[T_i(n)] \leq 3 + \frac{16\ln n}{\Delta_i^2}.$$

Plugging into $R_n = \sum_i \Delta_i\, \mathbb{E}[T_i(n)]$ (with $\Delta_1 = 0$) concludes the proof. □

0.11.7 Simulations and comparison with ETC

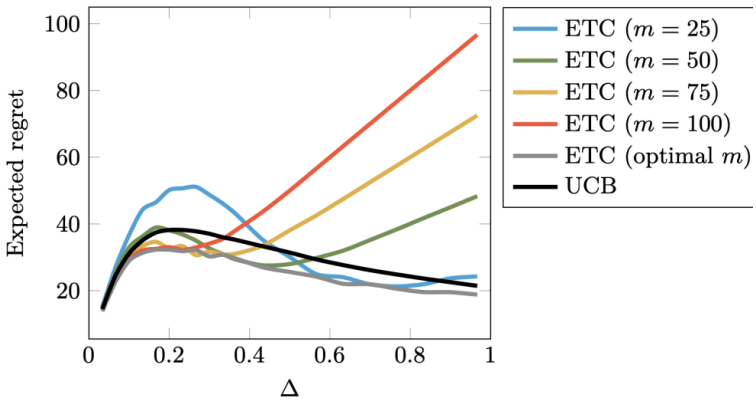
Variation with Δ

Setting: Bernoulli rewards with means $[0.5 - \frac{\Delta}{2}, 0.5 + \frac{\Delta}{2}]$.



- Sublinear regret for all values of Δ, with a *fixed* hyperparameter δ.
- The cumulative regret increases inversely with Δ (consistent with the $\frac{\ln n}{\Delta}$ term of the bound).
- The slope gradually decreases with time, signifying the shift from exploration to exploitation.
- The initial regret slope is higher for large Δ, due to expensive exploration (each pull of the bad arm costs Δ).

UCB versus ETC



UCB performs similarly to ETC with an optimally tuned m, *without* knowing the optimal m (i.e., without knowing the suboptimality gap). Figure from Chapter 7 of Lattimore & Szepesvári.

Remark 18 (Comparison of the bounds for $k = 2$)**.** For ETC with the optimal $m = \frac{4}{\Delta^2} \ln \frac{n\Delta^2}{4}$ (previous lecture), plugging into $R_n \leq m\Delta + n\Delta \exp(-m\Delta^2/4)$ gives $R_n \lesssim \frac{4}{\Delta}\left(1 + \ln \frac{n\Delta^2}{4}\right)$, also of order $\frac{\ln n}{\Delta}$. UCB achieves the same order, $\frac{16 \ln n}{\Delta} + 3\Delta$, but with a parameter $\delta = 1/n^2$ that does not depend on Δ.

0.12 Summary

- **Adaptive Explore-then-Commit**: the exploration length becomes a data-dependent stopping time. Explore in round robin until the confidence interval of the empirically best arm separates from all the others ($LCB_{a^*} > UCB_a$ for all $a \neq a^*$), then commit. Gives sublinear regret in practice; δ must be small enough (decreasing with n) to avoid mistaken commitments, but not too small to avoid over-exploration.
- **Confidence bounds**: for σ-subgaussian rewards and n samples, $UCB/LCB = \hat{\mu}_n \pm \sigma\sqrt{2\ln(2/\delta)/n}$.
- **Sequential elimination**: the right extension of ETC to $k > 2$ arms: instead of waiting for the best arm to dominate all others, eliminate any arm whose confidence interval is dominated. Proceeds in phases of random length, with decreasing instantaneous regret.
- **UCB algorithm**: $A_t = \arg\max_a \hat{\mu}_a(t-1) + \sqrt{2\ln(1/\delta)/T_a(t-1)}$. It quantifies uncertainty with confidence intervals and acts *optimistically in the face of uncertainty*; it has a smooth transition from exploration to exploitation (exploration never stops completely, but fades out).
- **Regret bound**: for a 1-subgaussian bandit and $\delta = 1/n^2$, $\mathbb{E}[T_i(n)] \leq 3 + \frac{16\ln n}{\Delta_i^2}$, hence $R_n \leq 3\sum_i \Delta_i + \sum_{i:\Delta_i>0} \frac{16\ln n}{\Delta_i}$: logarithmic regret without knowing the gaps. Proof technique: good event G_i (μ_1 below its UCB at all times, and arm i's UCB below μ_1 after u_i pulls), $T_i(n) \leq u_i$ on G_i, union bound + concentration for $\mathbb{P}(G_i^c)$, and tuning of u_i.

Lecture 5 — 2026-10-07: A Deeper Dive into Unstructured Bandits

In the previous lecture, we introduced the UCB algorithm and proved a logarithmic, *problem-dependent* regret bound for it, assuming the horizon n is known in advance. This lecture digs deeper into unstructured (stochastic, finite-armed) bandits along four directions:

- a **problem-independent** regret bound for UCB, of order $\sqrt{kn\ln n}$, which remains meaningful when the gaps Δ_i are arbitrarily small;
- an **asymptotic (anytime) version of UCB**, which does not need to know the horizon n and can run forever;
- **Thompson Sampling**, a randomized, Bayesian alternative to UCB;
- **best-arm identification**, a *pure exploration* problem where the goal is no longer to minimize regret but to find the best arm, with the **sequential halving** algorithm.

0.13 Recap

0.13.1 The UCB algorithm

Notation:

- $\hat{\mu}_i(t)$: estimate of the mean reward of arm i at time t;
- $T_i(t)$: number of pulls of arm i at time t;
- upper confidence bound of arm i at time t (for 1-subgaussian rewards):

$$UCB_i(t,\delta) = \hat{\mu}_i(t) + \sqrt{\frac{2\ln(1/\delta)}{T_i(t)}}, \qquad UCB_i(t,\delta) = \infty \text{ if } T_i(t) = 0.$$

UCB algorithm:

for $t = 1, 2, \ldots, n$ **do**:
choose $A_t = \arg\max_i UCB_i(t-1,\delta)$;
observe X_t and update $UCB_{A_t}(t,\delta)$.

0.13.2 Regret and the UCB regret bound

- **Instantaneous regret** at round t: $\mu^* - \mu_{A_t} = \Delta_{A_t}$.
- **Cumulative regret**: $R_n = \sum_{t=1}^{n} \mathbb{E}[\mu^* - X_t]$.
- **Regret decomposition**: $R_n = \sum_{i \in [k]} \Delta_i \, \mathbb{E}[T_i(n)]$.
- Sublinear cumulative regret $\Leftrightarrow$ vanishing instantaneous regret.

Theorem 10 (Regret of UCB, recap)**.** *For the UCB algorithm applied to a stochastic* 1*-subgaussian bandit with* k *arms and an error tolerance* $\delta = 1/n^2$*,*

$$R_n \leq 3 \sum_{i=1}^{k} \Delta_i + \sum_{i:\Delta_i > 0} \frac{16 \ln n}{\Delta_i}.$$

0.13.3 Proof strategy (recap)

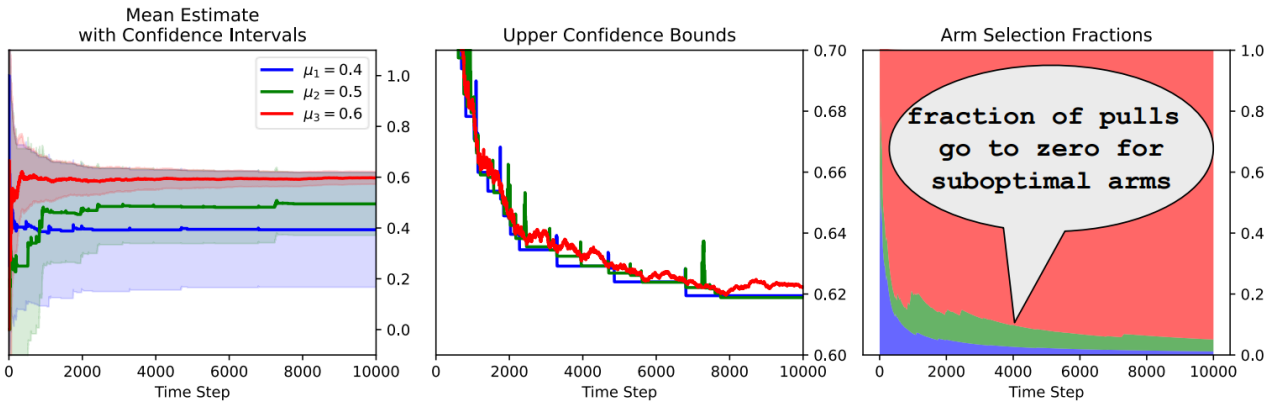
To bound the regret, it suffices to bound $\mathbb{E}[T_i(n)]$ for each suboptimal arm i, since $R_n = \sum_i \Delta_i \, \mathbb{E}[T_i(n)]$. The proof had four steps:

1. Define a **good event** G_i: (1) μ_1 is always below its own UCB, and (2) μ_1 is above the UCB of arm i after u_i pulls of i.
2. Show that if G_i holds, then $T_i(n) \leq u_i$.
3. Show that if u_i is large enough, then G_i is very likely.
4. Make a specific choice $u_i = \frac{8 \ln(1/\delta)}{\Delta_i^2}$ (i.e. $c = 1/2$), which gives $\mathbb{E}[T_i(n)] \leq 3 + \frac{16 \ln n}{\Delta_i^2}$.

0.14 UCB in practice: confidence intervals and the role of δ

0.14.1 Evolution of the confidence intervals

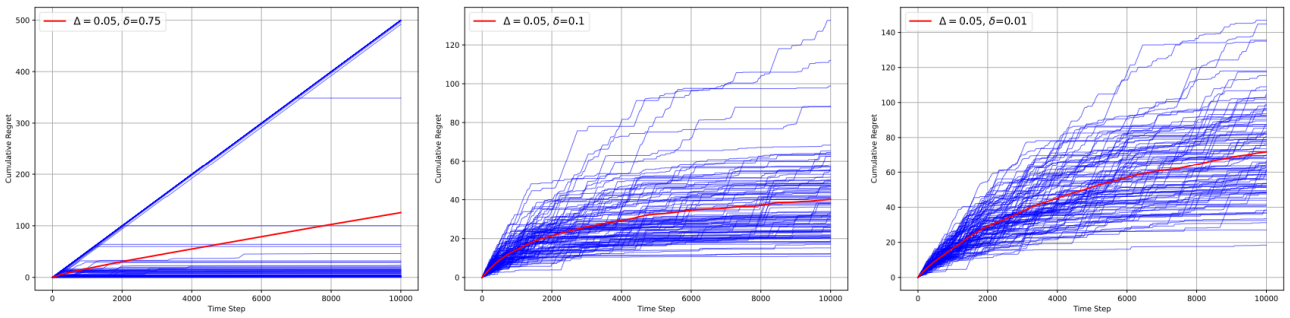
Setting: three-armed Bernoulli bandit with means $[0.4, 0.5, 0.6]$.



- The **upper confidence bounds of the arms are nearly identical throughout**. This is a direct consequence of the algorithm: whenever one arm's UCB is the largest, that arm is pulled, its bonus shrinks and its UCB comes down towards the others. UCB thus keeps all the UCBs "balanced".
- The **worse the arm, the less often it is played**: to have the same UCB as a better arm, a worse arm (lower $\hat{\mu}_i$) needs a larger bonus, i.e. fewer pulls. Worse arms therefore have wider confidence intervals.
- The fraction of pulls $T_i(t)/t$ goes to zero for suboptimal arms (they are pulled only $O(\ln t)$ times).

0.14.2 The effect of δ

Setting: two-armed Bernoulli bandit with means $[0.5 - \Delta/2,\ 0.5 + \Delta/2]$.



- Smaller $\delta \Rightarrow$ larger confidence intervals $\Rightarrow$ more exploration.
- **Too large** δ (under-exploration): narrow intervals, so there is a real chance that the best arm gets unlucky early, its UCB drops below the mean of the other arm, and the algorithm effectively "commits" to the wrong arm $\Rightarrow$ large (linear) regret.
- **Too small** δ (over-exploration): very wide intervals, the bonus dominates the empirical mean for a long time and suboptimal arms are pulled too often $\Rightarrow$ large regret.
- In between, correct exploration gives the smallest regret. This is the same qualitative behavior as for adaptive ETC.

0.15 A problem-independent regret bound for UCB

0.15.1 Motivation

The bound we proved,

$$R_n \le 3\sum_{i=1}^{k} \Delta_i + \sum_{i:\Delta_i>0} \frac{16 \ln n}{\Delta_i},$$

is **problem-dependent**: it depends on the gaps of the instance. If some Δ_i is arbitrarily small, the bound blows up and becomes meaningless: it can be much larger than the trivial bound

$$R_n = \sum_i \Delta_i \, \mathbb{E}[T_i(n)] \le \Delta_{\max} \sum_i \mathbb{E}[T_i(n)] = n\,\Delta_{\max}, \qquad \Delta_{\max} = \max_i \Delta_i,$$

which always holds (at most, we pay the largest gap at every round). For instance, with $\Delta_i = 10^{-6}$ and $n = 10^4$, the term $\frac{16 \ln n}{\Delta_i} \approx 1.5 \cdot 10^8$, while $n\Delta_{\max} \le 10^4$ for rewards in $[0, 1]$. Yet, intuitively, an arm with a tiny gap costs almost nothing per pull: even if it is pulled at every round, it contributes at most $n\Delta_i$ to the regret. Can we get a **problem-independent** (worst-case) bound, that holds uniformly over all instances?

Theorem 11 (Alternate (problem-independent) regret bound for UCB)**.** *For the UCB algorithm applied to a stochastic* 1*-subgaussian bandit with* k *arms and an error tolerance* $\delta = 1/n^2$*, the regret satisfies*

$$R_n \le 3\sum_{i=1}^{k} \Delta_i + 8\sqrt{kn \ln n}.$$

Remark 19.
- We trade the term $\sum_{i\in[k]} 1/\Delta_i$ (times $\ln n$) for a term $\sqrt{nk}$ (times $\sqrt{\ln n}$).
- This bound is sublinear for *every* instance, independently of the gaps: $R_n = O(\sqrt{kn \ln n})$.

The term $3\sum_i \Delta_i$ does not grow with n (and is at most $3k$ for rewards in $[0,1]$).

- The algorithm is **unchanged**: this is merely a different proof strategy. Both bounds hold simultaneously, and $R_n \le \min(\text{both})$.

0.15.2 Proof

Ingredients

Recall the main ingredients of the previous proof:

- Regret decomposition lemma: $R_n = \sum_i \Delta_i \, \mathbb{E}[T_i(n)]$.
- Bound derived from the concentration inequality: $\mathbb{E}[T_i(n)] \le 3 + \frac{16 \ln n}{\Delta_i^2}$.
- A **trivial bound**: $\mathbb{E}[T_i(n)] \le n$ (for all arms, under all conditions). More precisely, $\sum_i T_i(n) = n$.

When is the trivial bound tighter than the concentration bound? When

$$\frac{16 \ln n}{\Delta_i^2} \ge n \iff \Delta_i \le \sqrt{\frac{16 \ln n}{n}}.$$

The regret from such an arm i is then at most

$$\Delta_i \, \mathbb{E}[T_i(n)] \le \sqrt{\frac{16 \ln n}{n}} \cdot n = O\big(\sqrt{n \ln n}\big).$$

So arms with very small gaps contribute at most $O(\sqrt{n \ln n})$ each, which suggests that the goal $R_n = O(\sqrt{nk \ln n})$ is reachable.

Refined strategy

- Split the arms into two sets, according to a threshold $\Delta > 0$ (a proof parameter, *not* known or used by the algorithm):
  - **nearly optimal arms**: $\Delta_i < \Delta$; use the trivial bound for these arms;
  - **clearly suboptimal arms**: $\Delta_i \ge \Delta$; use the concentration bound for these arms.
- Optimize Δ to get the best expression.

Computation

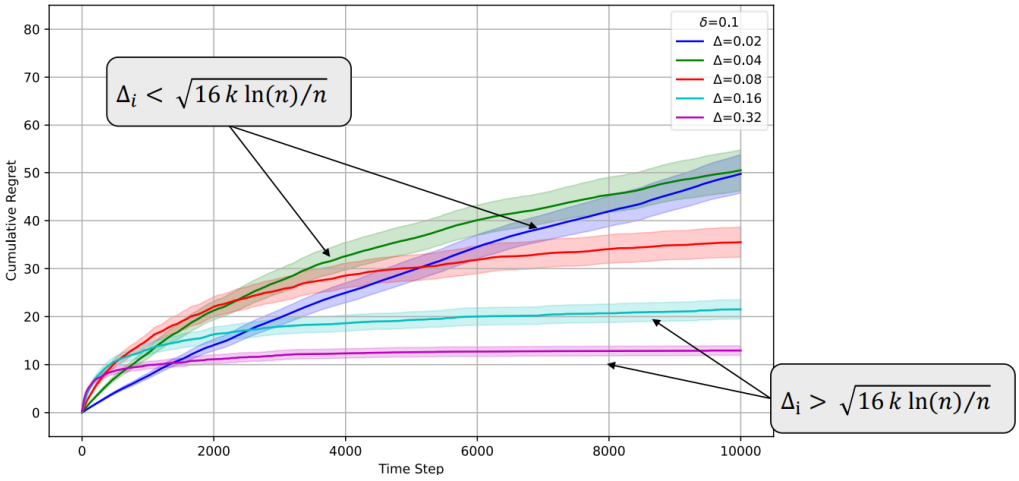
$$\begin{aligned}
R_n &= \sum_i \Delta_i \, \mathbb{E}[T_i(n)] = \sum_{i:\Delta_i<\Delta} \Delta_i \, \mathbb{E}[T_i(n)] + \sum_{i:\Delta_i\ge\Delta} \Delta_i \, \mathbb{E}[T_i(n)] \\
&\le n\Delta + \sum_{i:\Delta_i\ge\Delta} \Delta_i \, \mathbb{E}[T_i(n)] && \text{since } \textstyle\sum_{i:\Delta_i<\Delta} \Delta_i \mathbb{E}[T_i(n)] \le \Delta \sum_i \mathbb{E}[T_i(n)] = n\Delta \\
&\le n\Delta + \sum_{i:\Delta_i\ge\Delta} \Delta_i \left(3 + \frac{16 \ln n}{\Delta_i^2}\right) && \text{concentration bound} \\
&= n\Delta + \sum_{i:\Delta_i\ge\Delta} \left(3\Delta_i + \frac{16 \ln n}{\Delta_i}\right) \\
&\le \sum_i 3\Delta_i + n\Delta + \frac{16k \ln n}{\Delta} && \text{since } \tfrac{1}{\Delta_i} \le \tfrac{1}{\Delta} \text{ and there are at most } k \text{ such arms.}
\end{aligned}$$

Optimizing Δ. The function $\Delta \mapsto n\Delta + \frac{16k \ln n}{\Delta}$ is minimized when its derivative $n - \frac{16k \ln n}{\Delta^2}$ vanishes, i.e. for

$$\Delta = \sqrt{\frac{16k \ln n}{n}}, \qquad \text{giving} \qquad n\Delta + \frac{16k \ln n}{\Delta} = 2\sqrt{16kn \ln n} = 8\sqrt{kn \ln n}.$$

Hence $R_n \le \sum_i 3\Delta_i + 8\sqrt{kn \ln n}$. □

0.15.3 Revisiting the regret plot



- It takes $O\left(\frac{\ln(1/\delta)}{\Delta^2}\right)$ pulls to separate two arms with gap Δ with probability $1-\delta$ (the confidence interval width $\sqrt{2\ln(1/\delta)/T}$ must become smaller than Δ).
- Δ_i **large** ($\Delta_i > \sqrt{16k\ln n/n}$) $\Rightarrow$ confidence intervals separate early (within the horizon) $\Rightarrow$ **logarithmic** regret curves (the regime of the problem-dependent bound).
- Δ_i **small** ($\Delta_i < \sqrt{16k\ln n/n}$) $\Rightarrow$ separation happens late (possibly not before n) $\Rightarrow$ faster-growing (almost linear) regret curves, but with a small slope Δ_i (the regime of the trivial bound).

0.16 Asymptotic UCB: unknown horizon

0.16.1 Motivation: why a fixed δ is not enough

So far, the horizon n was fixed a priori (and used to set $\delta = 1/n^2$). This makes sense in some applications, not in others. What happens when we do not know the horizon? Equivalently: what if we want UCB to run forever?

- The main concern is that we must **eliminate any possibility of persistent error**: any error probability, however small, could lead to a large (infinite!) cumulative regret.
- In the current formulation, the chance of error is about the chance of the concentration event failing, which is about δ.
  - We cannot choose $\delta = 0$: the confidence interval would be infinite.
  - We cannot choose a constant $\delta > 0$: there is then a small (constant) probability of getting into a bad configuration at some time t (e.g. the best arm gets unlucky samples, its UCB drops below the mean of a suboptimal arm, and it is ignored forever) $\Rightarrow$ the regret grows linearly forever, so the expected regret is not sublinear.
- In effect, we need $\delta \to 0$ over time.
- Consequently, we need $T_i(n) \to \infty$ for *all* arms (no arm can be abandoned for good); we just control *how quickly* suboptimal arms are pulled.

0.16.2 Algorithm

The fact that $\delta \to 0$ over time is reflected in the confidence intervals:

- originally: $UCB_i(t,\delta) = \hat{\mu}_i(t) + \sqrt{\frac{2\ln(1/\delta)}{T_i(t)}}$;
- new formulation: $UCB_i(t) = \hat{\mu}_i(t) + \sqrt{\frac{8\ln t}{T_i(t)}}$.

This corresponds to choosing a time-varying confidence level $\delta_t = t^{-4}$, since $2\ln(1/\delta_t) = 2\ln(t^4) = 8\ln t$. The rest of the algorithm remains identical!

Definition 22. (Asymptotic UCB).

for $t = 1, 2, \ldots$ **do**:

choose $A_t = \arg\max_i \left(\hat{\mu}_i(t-1) + \sqrt{\frac{8\ln t}{T_i(t-1)}} \right)$ (with the index $= \infty$ if $T_i(t-1) = 0$);

observe X_t and update $UCB_i(t)$ for all i.

Remark 20.

- Now *all* the UCBs must be updated at each round, not only the one of the pulled arm: the bonus depends on t through $\ln t$.
- If an arm is not played for a long time, its confidence interval slowly grows (its T_i is frozen but $\ln t$ increases). Its UCB grows (very slowly) without bound, so an arm cannot be neglected forever: each arm is pulled every so often.
- Hence no "error" (mistake in identifying the best arm) is permanent.
- This is **not** the same as $\delta = 1/n^2$ in the proof of last week: that δ was fixed over time (but depended on the known horizon n), whereas here δ_t gradually decreases with the current time t, and no knowledge of n is needed ("anytime" algorithm).

Theorem 12 (Regret of asymptotic UCB)**.** *For any 1-subgaussian bandit, the regret of the asymptotic UCB algorithm satisfies, for all n,*

$$R_n \le \sum_{i:\Delta_i>0} \left(4\Delta_i + \frac{32\ln n}{\Delta_i} \right), \qquad \textit{hence} \qquad \limsup_{n\to\infty} \frac{R_n}{\ln n} \le \sum_{i:\Delta_i>0} \frac{32}{\Delta_i}.$$

0.16.3 Regret bound: proof sketch

As in the fixed-horizon version, the key is to prove that, for every suboptimal arm i,

$$\mathbb{E}[T_i(n)] \le \frac{32\ln n}{\Delta_i^2} + 4,$$

and the theorem then follows from the regret decomposition. We broadly follow the same steps:

- Define good events such that, under the good event ("normal circumstances"), the number of pulls of a suboptimal arm is bounded by some u_i.
- Show that the probability of the bad event is small (concentration inequality).

Differences from the fixed-horizon case:

- the good event now **depends on time** t;
- a careful use of the union bound (over rounds, then over the possible numbers of pulls).

As before, assume without loss of generality that arm 1 is optimal.

Defining good events: fixed horizon versus asymptotic

Fixed horizon	**Asymptotic**
$G = G_1 \cap G_i$, where	$G_t = G_{1,t} \cap G_{i,t}$, where
$G_1 = \left\{\mu_1 < \min_{t\in[n]} \hat{\mu}_1(t) + \sqrt{\frac{2}{T_1(t)} \ln \frac{1}{\delta}}\right\}$	$G_{1,t} = \left\{\mu_1 < \hat{\mu}_1(t) + \sqrt{\frac{8}{T_1(t)} \ln t}\right\}$
$G_i = \left\{\hat{\mu}_{iu_i} + \sqrt{\frac{2}{u_i} \ln \frac{1}{\delta}} < \mu_1\right\}$	$G_{i,t} = \left\{\mu_i > \hat{\mu}_i(t) - \sqrt{\frac{8}{T_i(t)} \ln t}\right\}$
Conditional on G: $T_i(n) \le \frac{8\ln(1/\delta)}{\Delta_i^2} =: u_i$.	Conditional on G_t: $T_i(t) \le \frac{32 \ln t}{\Delta_i^2} =: u_i(t)$ **or** arm i is not pulled in round t.

Interpretation of the asymptotic good events:

- $G_{1,t}$: the UCB of arm 1 is above its true mean at time t;
- $G_{i,t}$: the LCB of arm i is below its true mean at time t.

The fixed-horizon good event is a single event covering the whole run; the asymptotic one is a family of events, one per round, and only requires the two confidence intervals to be correct *at round* t.

Remark 21 (Indices)**.** As in the slides, we write all quantities "at time t" to lighten notation. Strictly speaking, the decision at round t uses $\hat{\mu}_i(t-1)$ and $T_i(t-1)$ (with the bonus $\sqrt{8\ln t / T_i(t-1)}$); the argument is identical.

Step 1: under G_t, a suboptimal arm with many pulls is not chosen

We need to show

$$G_t \cap \{A_t = i\} \Rightarrow T_i(t) \le \frac{32 \ln t}{\Delta_i^2}, \qquad \text{equivalently} \qquad G_t \cap \left\{T_i(t) > \frac{32 \ln t}{\Delta_i^2}\right\} \Rightarrow A_t \neq i.$$

This uses elementary logic: $A \Rightarrow B \iff (B^c \Rightarrow A^c)$, and more generally $C \cap A \Rightarrow B \iff (C \cap B^c \Rightarrow A^c)$. (Also: $A \Rightarrow B \cup C \iff (A \cap B^c \Rightarrow C)$, which gives the "$T_i(t) \le u_i(t)$ *or* arm i not pulled" form of the table.)

Proof. Assume that both G_t and $T_i(t) > \frac{32 \ln t}{\Delta_i^2}$ occur.

- From $T_i(t) > \frac{32 \ln t}{\Delta_i^2}$: $\Delta_i^2 > \frac{32 \ln t}{T_i(t)} = 4 \cdot \frac{8 \ln t}{T_i(t)}$, so

$$\Delta_i > 2\sqrt{\frac{8 \ln t}{T_i(t)}}.$$

- From $G_{i,t}$ and $G_{1,t}$, using $\mu_1 = \mu_i + \Delta_i$:

$$\underbrace{\hat{\mu}_i(t) - \sqrt{\frac{8 \ln t}{T_i(t)}}}_{LCB_i(t)} + \Delta_i < \mu_i + \Delta_i = \mu_1 < \underbrace{\hat{\mu}_1(t) + \sqrt{\frac{8 \ln t}{T_1(t)}}}_{UCB_1(t)}.$$

- Combining, since $\Delta_i > 2\sqrt{8 \ln t / T_i(t)}$:

$$UCB_i(t) = \hat{\mu}_i(t) + \sqrt{\frac{8 \ln t}{T_i(t)}} = \hat{\mu}_i(t) - \sqrt{\frac{8 \ln t}{T_i(t)}} + 2\sqrt{\frac{8 \ln t}{T_i(t)}} < \hat{\mu}_i(t) - \sqrt{\frac{8 \ln t}{T_i(t)}} + \Delta_i < UCB_1(t).$$

So $UCB_i(t) < UCB_1(t)$, and arm i is not pulled in round t. □

Graphically, on the good event: $\cdots < LCB_i(t) < \mu_i < \cdots < \mu_1 < UCB_1(t)$, and once $T_i(t)$ is large, the interval of arm i is narrower than $\Delta_i/2$ on each side, so $UCB_i(t) < \mu_1 < UCB_1(t)$.

Step 2: bounding $\mathbb{E}[T_i(n)]$

Fixed horizon (recap): $\mathbb{E}[T_i(n)] \le \mathbb{E}[\mathbb{I}\{G\}T_i(n)] + \mathbb{E}[\mathbb{I}\{G^c\}T_i(n)] \le u_i + \mathbb{P}(G^c)\,n$, with $\mathbb{P}(G_i^c) \le n\delta + \exp\left(-\frac{u_i c^2 \Delta_i^2}{2}\right)$; put together, this gives the desired result. This approach is **too loose for the asymptotic version** ("$n = \infty$"): the term $\mathbb{P}(G^c)\,n$ requires $\mathbb{P}(G^c) \lesssim 1/n$ for a known n.

Asymptotic: we decompose *round by round*. Since $\mathbb{I}\{G_t\} + \mathbb{I}\{G_t^c\} \equiv 1$,

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbb{E}\big[\mathbb{I}\{A_t = i\}\big] &= \mathbb{E}\big[\mathbb{I}\{G_t\}\,\mathbb{I}\{A_t = i\}\big] + \mathbb{E}\big[\mathbb{I}\{G_t^c\}\,\mathbb{I}\{A_t = i\}\big] \\ &\le \mathbb{E}\big[\mathbb{I}\{T_i(t) \le u_i(t)\}\,\mathbb{I}\{A_t = i\}\big] + \mathbb{E}\big[\mathbb{I}\{G_t^c\}\big],\end{aligned}$$

using step 1 for the first term ($G_t \cap \{A_t = i\} \subseteq \{T_i(t) \le u_i(t)\} \cap \{A_t = i\}$) and $\mathbb{I}\{A_t = i\} \le 1$ for the second. Summing over rounds, and using $u_i(t) \le u_i(n)$ for $t \le n$:

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbb{E}[T_i(n)] = \sum_{t\in[n]} \mathbb{E}\big[\mathbb{I}\{A_t = i\}\big] &\le \sum_{t\in[n]} \mathbb{E}\big[\mathbb{I}\{T_i(t) \le u_i(n)\}\,\mathbb{I}\{A_t = i\}\big] + \sum_{t\in[n]} \mathbb{P}(G_t^c) \\ &\le u_i(n) + 1 + \sum_{t=1}^{\infty} \mathbb{P}(G_t^c) \\ &\le \frac{32\ln n}{\Delta_i^2} + 1 + \sum_{t=1}^{\infty} \frac{2}{t^3} \le \frac{32\ln n}{\Delta_i^2} + 4.\end{aligned}$$

Explanations:

- **Counting argument**: $\sum_t \mathbb{I}\{T_i(t) \le u_i(n)\}\,\mathbb{I}\{A_t = i\}$ counts the rounds in which arm i is pulled while its counter is at most $u_i(n)$. How many times can one increment a counter while it is less than u_i? At most $u_i + 1$ times (each pull increments T_i by one).
- $\mathbb{P}(G_t^c) \le 2t^{-3}$ (shown below), and $\sum_{t=1}^{\infty} \frac{1}{t^3} \le 1 + \int_1^{\infty} \frac{1}{t^3}\,dt = 1.5$, so $\sum_t \frac{2}{t^3} \le 3$. Crucially, this series **converges**: the total probability of bad events over an infinite horizon is finite. This is why δ_t must decrease fast enough ($\delta_t = t^{-4}$).

Step 3: bounding $\mathbb{P}(G_t^c)$

We need to show $\mathbb{P}(G_{1,t}^c) \le t^{-3}$; the same bound holds for $\mathbb{P}(G_{i,t}^c)$ (by symmetry, for the lower tail). Together, by the union bound,

$$\mathbb{P}(G_t^c) \le \mathbb{P}(G_{1,t}^c) + \mathbb{P}(G_{i,t}^c) \le 2t^{-3}.$$

As in the fixed-horizon proof, $T_1(t)$ is random, so we take a union over all its possible values $s \in [t]$ (if $T_1(t) = 0$, the UCB is infinite and $G_{1,t}$ holds), and work with $\hat{\mu}_{1,s}$, the average of the first s samples of arm 1:

$$G_{1,t}^c = \left\{\mu_1 \ge \hat{\mu}_1(t) + \sqrt{\frac{8\ln t}{T_1(t)}}\right\} \subseteq \bigcup_{s=1}^{t} \left\{\mu_1 \ge \hat{\mu}_{1,s} + \sqrt{\frac{8\ln t}{s}}\right\}.$$

Then, by the union bound and the Chernoff bound (for s i.i.d. 1-subgaussian samples, $\mathbb{P}\big(\mu \ge \hat{\mu}_s + \sqrt{2\ln(1/\delta)/s}\big) \le \delta$), with $\delta = t^{-4}$:

$$\mathbb{P}(G_{1,t}^c) \le \sum_{s=1}^{t} \mathbb{P}\left(\mu_1 \ge \hat{\mu}_{1,s} + \sqrt{\frac{8\ln t}{s}}\right) = \sum_{s=1}^{t} \mathbb{P}\left(\mu_1 \ge \hat{\mu}_{1,s} + \sqrt{\frac{2\ln(1/t^{-4})}{s}}\right) \le \sum_{s=1}^{t} t^{-4} = t^{-3}.$$

Remark 22 (Why t^{-4}?)**.** The union over the t possible values of $T_1(t)$ costs a factor t, so the per-s error probability δ_t must satisfy that $\sum_t t\,\delta_t$ converges. With $\delta_t = t^{-4}$, we get $\sum_t 2t^{-3} < \infty$. (A choice like $\delta_t = t^{-2}$ would give $\sum_t t^{-1} = \infty$, which is not enough for this proof.)

Conclusion

Multiplying by Δ_i and summing over suboptimal arms gives $R_n \leq \sum_{i:\Delta_i>0} \left(4\Delta_i + \frac{32 \ln n}{\Delta_i}\right)$. Dividing by $\ln n$ and letting $n \to \infty$:

$$\limsup_{n\to\infty} \frac{R_n}{\ln n} \leq \sum_{i:\Delta_i>0} \frac{32}{\Delta_i}.$$

This is the **same order** as the result of last week ($\ln n/\Delta_i$), but now we **do not need to know** n **a priori**! The price is only a worse constant (32 instead of 16).

0.16.4 Asymptotically optimal UCB

The constant can be squeezed further. Algorithm 6 and Theorem 8.1 in Lattimore & Szepesvári give an asymptotically optimal result:

$$\limsup_{n\to\infty} \frac{R_n}{\ln n} \leq \sum_{i:\Delta_i>0} \frac{2}{\Delta_i}.$$

Differences with our version:

- the exploration bonus is $\sqrt{\frac{2 \ln f(t)}{T_i(t-1)}}$ with $f(t) = 1+t\ln^2(t)$, instead of $f(t) = t^4$ (i.e. $\sqrt{8 \ln t/T_i(t-1)}$): a much smaller bonus, hence less exploration;
- the good events measure the UCB crossing the threshold $\mu_1 - \varepsilon$ rather than μ_1 (a finer analysis).

"Asymptotically optimal" means that no reasonable algorithm can have a better constant: this matches the lower bound of Lai and Robbins (see below), which we do not study in this course.

0.16.5 UCB: a long history

- **1985**: Lai and Robbins give a clean formulation of the multi-armed bandit problem.
  - They proved the fundamental **logarithmic lower bound** (we do not study lower bounds; they serve to understand the best possible performance of any algorithm).
  - They also introduced the idea of **optimism** and of using confidence bounds.
- **1985–1995**: UCB algorithm proposed, asymptotic regret bounds.
- **2002**: Auer et al. proposed the **UCB1** algorithm and analysed its (finite-time) regret. This is what we saw in class.
- **2010–2017**: asymptotically optimal and minimax-optimal algorithms: MOSS, KL-UCB, etc.
- Coming up: Thompson Sampling, an algorithm from **1933**!

0.17 Thompson Sampling

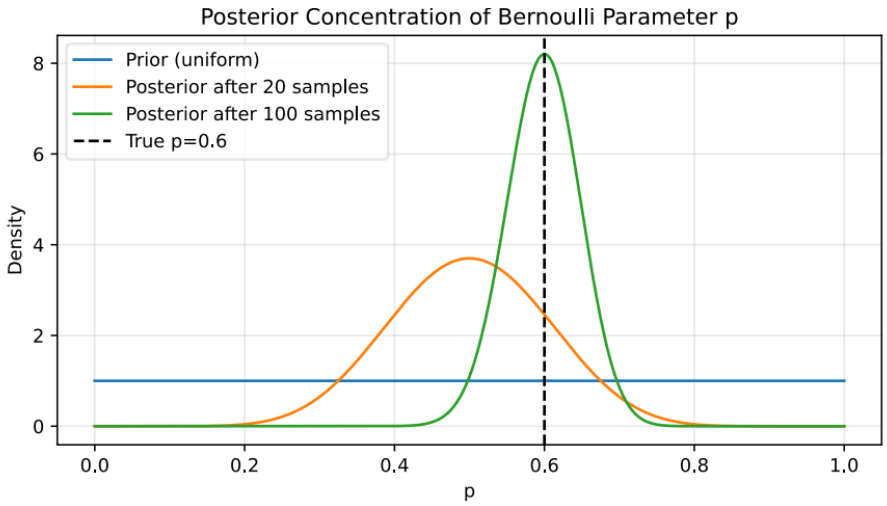
0.17.1 Prelude: Bayesian statistics

In Bayesian statistics, we maintain a **belief distribution** over unknown quantities.

- The belief distribution measures all we know about the unknown.
- Without any data, the belief distribution has a large variance.
- With more data, the belief distribution concentrates around the true parameter.

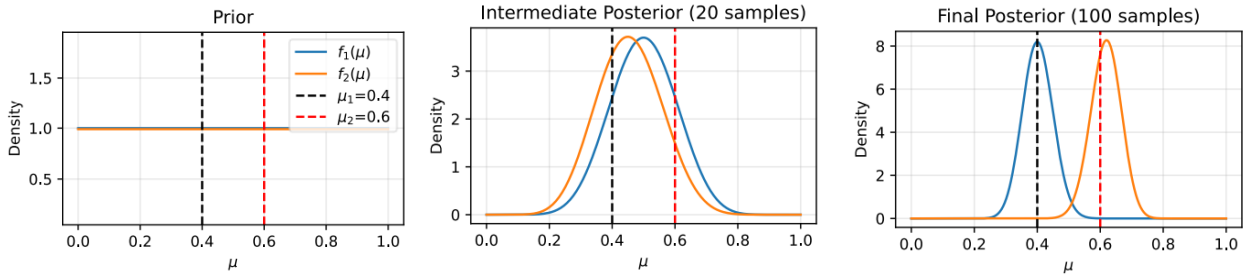
Formally, the belief is updated with Bayes' rule: starting from a **prior** $f_0(\mu)$, after observing data D we get the **posterior**

$$f(\mu \mid D) = \frac{\mathbb{P}(D \mid \mu)\, f_0(\mu)}{\int \mathbb{P}(D \mid \mu')\, f_0(\mu')\, d\mu'} \propto \mathbb{P}(D \mid \mu)\, f_0(\mu).$$



0.17.2 Bayesian view of bandits

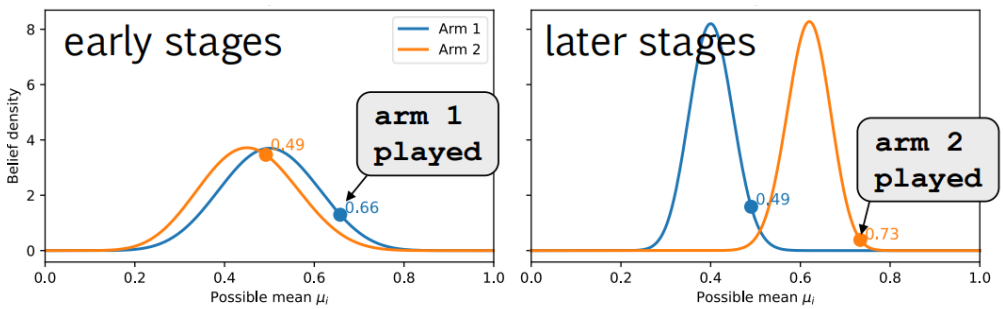
- In multi-armed bandits with $\{0, 1\}$ rewards, the unknown variables are the mean rewards of each arm: $\mu_1, \mu_2, \ldots, \mu_k$.
- We maintain a belief $f_{i,t}(\mu)$ for all arms i, at all times t, instead of $\hat{\mu}_i$ and a UCB.
- Initially, we know nothing about μ_i: any value in $[0, 1]$ is equally likely. The **prior** belief $f_{i,0}(\mu)$ for each arm i is the uniform distribution on $[0, 1]$.
- Over time, we pull arms and observe rewards, and the belief $f_{i,t}(\cdot)$ concentrates near μ_i.



0.17.3 Algorithm

Thompson Sampling is a **randomized** algorithm for multi-armed bandits.

- The algorithm maintains a belief distribution over the possible arm values at all times. Contrast: UCB maintains a point estimate and a confidence interval of the arm values.
- At each step, the algorithm:
  - samples values $\tilde{\mu}_1, \tilde{\mu}_2, \ldots, \tilde{\mu}_k$ according to the belief distributions;
  - plays the arm with the highest sampled value (a form of optimism);
  - observes the data and updates the belief of the played arm.



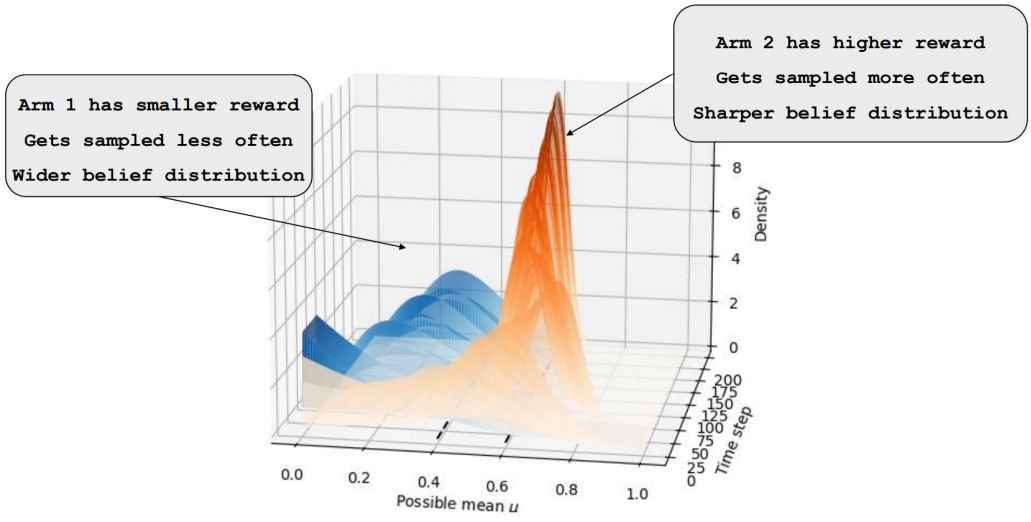
Definition 23. (Thompson Sampling).

for $t = 1, 2, \ldots$ **do**:
  for $i = 1, 2, \ldots, k$ **do**: sample $\tilde{\mu}_i(t) \sim f_{i,t}(\cdot)$;
  choose $A_t = \arg\max_i \tilde{\mu}_i(t)$;
  observe X_t, update $f_{A_t,t}(\cdot)$.

0.17.4 Intuition

- Exploration happens through the **randomness in the sampling**.
- Initially, beliefs are weak ⇒ larger variance ⇒ samples are spread out, any arm can come out on top ⇒ more exploration.
- Over time, beliefs concentrate, samples are close to the true means ⇒ the arm with the highest mean almost always wins ⇒ exploitation.
- Smooth transition from exploration to exploitation, and the beliefs of the candidates for best arm concentrate more quickly (they are sampled more).
- Equivalently, Thompson Sampling plays each arm with the (posterior) *probability that it is the best arm*: an arm that is clearly worse has a tiny probability of producing the largest sample, so it is rarely played.

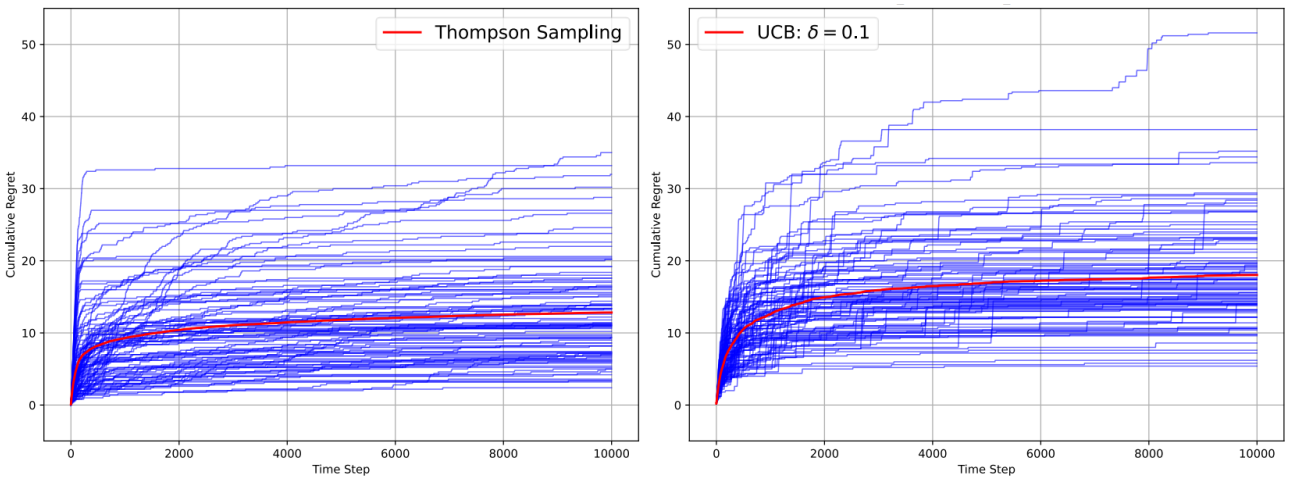
Evolution of the posterior



This is the Bayesian analogue of what we observed for UCB: worse arms have wider confidence intervals.

Thompson Sampling versus UCB

Setting: two-armed Bernoulli bandit with means $[0.4, 0.6]$.



- The regret curves of Thompson Sampling are similar to those of UCB.
- Smooth exploration-exploitation tradeoff.
- In practice, Thompson Sampling can be better than UCB.

0.17.5 Calculating posteriors: Beta-Bernoulli

In the Bernoulli bandit setting (rewards 0 or 1), we use a convenient **conjugate prior**: the **Beta distribution**.

Definition 24 (Beta distribution)**.** The Beta distribution with parameters $\alpha, \beta > 0$ has density on $[0, 1]$

$$f(x) = \frac{x^{\alpha-1}(1-x)^{\beta-1}}{B(\alpha, \beta)}, \qquad B(\alpha, \beta) = \frac{\Gamma(\alpha)\Gamma(\beta)}{\Gamma(\alpha+\beta)}.$$

Its mean is $\frac{\alpha}{\alpha+\beta}$, and its variance $\frac{\alpha\beta}{(\alpha+\beta)^2(\alpha+\beta+1)}$ decreases as $\alpha+\beta$ grows. Beta$(1, 1)$ is the uniform distribution on $[0, 1]$.

- Belief for arm i: $\mu_i \sim \text{Beta}(\alpha_i, \beta_i)$, where α_i counts the past successes and β_i the past failures (starting from $\alpha_i = \beta_i = 1$ for the uniform prior, so $\alpha_i - 1$ successes and $\beta_i - 1$ failures have been observed).
- After observing a reward $r_t \in \{0, 1\}$ from arm i:

$$\alpha_i \leftarrow \alpha_i + r_t, \qquad \beta_i \leftarrow \beta_i + (1 - r_t).$$

- The posterior remains a Beta distribution (this is what *conjugate* means): updating beliefs just amounts to incrementing these two counters.
- More data $\Rightarrow$ the posterior becomes narrower (more confident).
- Successes (1) shift the density rightward; failures (0) shift it leftward.

Remark 23 (Why the posterior stays Beta)**.** With a Beta(α, β) prior and one Bernoulli observation $r \in \{0, 1\}$ (likelihood $\mu^r(1-\mu)^{1-r}$), Bayes' rule gives

$$f(\mu \mid r) \propto \mu^r(1-\mu)^{1-r} \cdot \mu^{\alpha-1}(1-\mu)^{\beta-1} = \mu^{(\alpha+r)-1}(1-\mu)^{(\beta+1-r)-1},$$

which is the (unnormalized) density of Beta$(\alpha + r, \beta + 1 - r)$.

Remark 24 (Example)**.** Arm i with a uniform prior, pulled 5 times with rewards $1, 0, 1, 1, 0$: the posterior is $\text{Beta}(1+3, 1+2) = \text{Beta}(4, 3)$, with mean $4/7$. Thompson Sampling draws $\tilde{\mu}_i \sim \text{Beta}(4, 3)$, compares it with the samples of the other arms, and plays the arm with the largest sample.

0.17.6 Some practical points

- Thompson Sampling has similar theoretical regret guarantees as UCB.
- In practice, it can sometimes achieve lower regret than UCB; it is usually competitive in performance. Benefits are seen more often in linear bandits (next lecture).
- Computing the posterior can be hard without conjugate priors! There are many techniques to sample from an un-normalized distribution (e.g. MCMC), and other techniques to approximate the posterior distribution.
- There is no hyperparameter to adjust the exploration-exploitation tradeoff (unlike δ in UCB). In practice, one can still:
  - speed up or slow down the update of the posterior;
  - or artificially inflate or reduce the variance of the belief distribution (more variance $\Rightarrow$ more exploration).
- Thompson Sampling, like UCB, is a method to minimize regret in bandits. But what if we are only interested in identifying the best arm?

0.18 Best-arm identification

0.18.1 Motivation

Suppose a company wants to test the efficacy of drugs on mice.

- There are a few different drug variants: these are the arms.
- We do not care about the outcome of the drug on the mice during the trial (no regret… poor mouse!).
- The only goal is to identify the best drug with high probability at the end of the trial.

How should the drugs be tried? (Source: Lattimore & Szepesvári, Chapter 33.)

0.18.2 Formulations

- **Basic formulation**: after n rounds of playing a multi-armed bandit, identify the best arm with high probability, i.e. return an arm i so as to minimize $\mathbb{P}(\mu^* - \mu_i > 0)$ (fixed-budget setting).
- **Slightly weaker requirement (PAC: probably approximately correct)**: return an arm i such that $\mathbb{P}(\mu^* - \mu_i > \epsilon) \leq \delta$. We allow an ϵ-suboptimal arm ("approximately correct"), with probability at least $1 - \delta$ ("probably").
- **Yet another alternative**: minimize the **simple regret** at time $n+1$, $\mathbb{E}[\mu^* - \mu_i]$ where i is the returned arm. This is different from cumulative regret minimization: only the quality of the final recommendation counts, not the rewards collected along the way.

0.18.3 Intuition: why is this different from regret minimization?

- Regret-minimizing algorithms play suboptimal arms only $O(\log n)$ times, with confidence intervals chosen such that the error probability is $\delta = O(n^{-2})$. Spending so few samples on suboptimal arms is good for regret, but not for distinguishing them precisely from the best arm.
- In best-arm identification, there is **no exploration-exploitation tradeoff**: it is **pure exploration**. Pulling a bad arm costs nothing in itself, so we pull suboptimal arms more often than in regret minimization.

Baseline: uniform exploration

Each arm is pulled n/k times, and we return the empirically best arm after round n. Assume arm 1 is the unique best arm. Using the union bound and then the Chernoff bound:

$$\mathbb{P}(\mu^* - \mu_{\hat{i}} > 0) \leq \sum_{i:\Delta_i>0} \mathbb{P}(\hat{\mu}_i \geq \hat{\mu}_1) \leq \sum_{i:\Delta_i>0} \exp\left(-\frac{(n/k)\Delta_i^2}{4}\right),$$

where $\hat{i}$ is the returned arm. Indeed, $(\hat{\mu}_i - \hat{\mu}_1) - (\mu_i - \mu_1)$ is the difference of two independent averages of n/k samples, hence $\sqrt{2k/n}$-subgaussian, so $\mathbb{P}(\hat{\mu}_i - \hat{\mu}_1 \geq 0) = \mathbb{P}\big((\hat{\mu}_i - \hat{\mu}_1) - (\mu_i - \mu_1) \geq \Delta_i\big) \leq \exp\left(-\frac{\Delta_i^2}{2\cdot 2k/n}\right)$.

Can we do better? Yes! There is no explore-exploit tradeoff, but there is still a benefit in **adaptively sampling some arms more than others**, based on the information collected so far: clearly bad arms can be discarded early, and the remaining budget spent on the hard comparisons between the top arms.

0.18.4 Sequential halving

Definition 25. (Sequential Halving for best-arm identification). Input: number of arms k, time horizon (budget) n.

Set the number of phases $L = \lceil \log_2 k \rceil$, active set $\mathcal{A}_1 = [k]$.
for $\ell = 1, 2, \ldots, L$ **do**:
  let $T_\ell = \left\lfloor \frac{n}{L\,|\mathcal{A}_\ell|} \right\rfloor$;
  play each arm in $\mathcal{A}_\ell$ exactly T_ℓ times;
  for each arm $i \in \mathcal{A}_\ell$, compute $\hat{\mu}_i^\ell$: the empirical mean of its last T_ℓ samples;
  $\mathcal{A}_{\ell+1} \leftarrow$ the top $\lceil |\mathcal{A}_\ell|/2 \rceil$ arms in $\mathcal{A}_\ell$ (according to $\hat{\mu}_i^\ell$).
return the (single) arm in $\mathcal{A}_{L+1}$.

Remark 25.
- It **eliminates the worst half of the arms in each phase**, which makes a more efficient use of the experiment budget.
- Each phase uses (at most) the same budget n/L, shared among fewer and fewer arms: T_ℓ **increases exponentially** in ℓ (it roughly doubles each phase). The arms that survive the longest (the best ones) get the most samples, i.e. the most precise estimates, which is exactly where precision is needed.
- In each phase, only the samples of that phase are used ("last T_ℓ samples"): this keeps the samples of different phases independent, which simplifies the analysis.
- Compare with sequential elimination (lecture 4): both remove arms progressively, but sequential halving uses a fixed schedule (fixed budget, one halving per phase) rather than confidence intervals.

0.18.5 Performance of sequential halving

Theorem 13 (Sequential halving)**.** *The sequential halving algorithm, applied to a stochastic* 1*-subgaussian bandit with* k *arms with mean vector* $\mu_1 > \mu_2 \geq \cdots \geq \mu_k$ *(arms sorted by decreasing mean) for* n *rounds, returns a suboptimal arm with probability at most*

$$3\log_2(k)\exp\left(-\frac{n}{16\,H_2(\mu)\log_2 k}\right), \qquad H_2(\mu) = \max_{j:\Delta_j>0}\frac{j}{\Delta_j^2}.$$

Remark 26 (Interpretation of H_2)**.** $H_2(\mu)$ measures the **difficulty** of the instance. The term j/Δ_j^2 is large when there are many arms (j arms at least as good as arm j) with small gaps. The error probability decays exponentially in $n/(H_2\log_2 k)$: a budget of order $H_2(\mu)\log k$ samples suffices to identify the best arm with high probability.

Case 1: all suboptimal arms have the same gap

$\mu_1 = 1$, $\mu_2 = \mu_3 = \cdots = \mu_k = 1-\Delta \Rightarrow H_2(\mu) = \max_j j/\Delta^2 = k/\Delta^2$.

- Error rate (exponent) for sequential halving: $\sim \frac{n\Delta^2}{k\log k}$.
- Uniform exploration is marginally better: exponent $\sim \frac{n\Delta^2}{k}$.

Here no arm can be discarded more easily than the others, so adaptivity does not help (and costs a $\log k$ factor).

Case 2: one arm is slightly worse, all others far worse

$\mu_1 = 1$, $\mu_2 = 1-\Delta$, $\mu_3 = \cdots = \mu_k = 0 \Rightarrow H_2(\mu) = \max\left(2/\Delta^2, \max_{j\geq 3} j\right) = 2/\Delta^2$ (for small Δ).

- Error rate for sequential halving: $\sim \frac{n\Delta^2}{\log k}$.
- Uniform exploration: the hard comparison between arms 1 and 2 only gets n/k samples per arm, so its exponent is $\sim \frac{n\Delta^2}{k}$.
- Sequential halving is **much better than uniform exploration, especially for large** k: it devotes more samples to deciding between arms 1 and 2, after quickly discarding the obviously bad arms.

0.19 Summary

- **Alternate regret bound for UCB**: $R_n \leq 3\sum_i \Delta_i + 8\sqrt{kn\ln n}$, i.e. $O(\sqrt{n})$ up to logarithmic factors, independently of the gaps. Proof: do not use the concentration inequality for arms with small gaps ($\Delta_i < \Delta$, use $\sum_i T_i(n) = n$ instead), use it for the others, then optimize the threshold $\Delta = \sqrt{16k\ln n/n}$. The algorithm is unchanged.
- **Role of δ in UCB**: too large $\Rightarrow$ risk of "committing" to a wrong arm; too small $\Rightarrow$ over-exploration. UCB keeps the UCBs of all arms nearly equal, and worse arms are played less often.
- **Asymptotic UCB** (L&S Chapter 8): unknown n, run forever. Index $\hat{\mu}_i(t-1) + \sqrt{8\ln t/T_i(t-1)}$ (i.e. $\delta_t = t^{-4}$): confidence intervals grow with time when an arm is not pulled, so the chance of a permanent error goes to zero. Similar regret result and proof as last time: $R_n \leq \sum_{i:\Delta_i>0}\left(4\Delta_i + \frac{32\ln n}{\Delta_i}\right)$, but now we do not need to know n. Proof: time-dependent good events G_t, round-by-round decomposition, counting argument, $\mathbb{P}(G_t^c) \leq 2t^{-3}$ (summable). Optimal constant: $2/\Delta_i$ (Lai–Robbins).
- **Thompson Sampling** (L&S Chapter 36): Bayesian perspective, randomized algorithm. Maintain a posterior per arm (Beta(α_i, β_i) for Bernoulli rewards, updated by counting successes and failures),

sample from each posterior, play the arm with the largest sample. Exploration comes from the randomness of the samples; similar guarantees as UCB, can be better in practice, no exploration hyperparameter.

- **Best-arm identification** (L&S Chapter 33): a pure exploration problem (fixed budget, PAC, or simple regret formulations). Suboptimal arms are pulled more often than in regret minimization. Uniform exploration has error $\leq \sum_i \exp(-n\Delta_i^2/(4k))$; **sequential halving** halves the active set in each of $\lceil \log_2 k \rceil$ phases and has error $\leq 3 \log_2 k \, \exp\big(-n/(16 H_2 \log_2 k)\big)$, much better when only a few arms are competitive.